

Mendel University in Brno
Faculty of Regional Development and International
Studies



**Assessment Of Working Conditions and Labor Rights in
Bangladesh's Ready-Made Garment Sector: A Case Study of
Gazipur District**

Diploma Thesis

Supervisor:

Ing. Ebo Tawiah Quartey, Ph.D.

Author

Md Harun Or Rashid

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Dedication

This dissertation is dedicated to my parents and family, whose constant encouragement, support, and sacrifices have been the foundation of my academic journey. Their belief in my abilities has inspired me to overcome challenges and remain committed to achieving my goals. I also dedicate this work to all garment workers whose hard work and resilience contribute significantly to economic development, yet whose voices often remain unheard. This study is a small effort to highlight their experiences and challenges. Finally, I dedicate this work to my teachers and mentors who have guided me with knowledge, patience, and motivation throughout this research journey.

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Abstract

This study examines the working conditions and labor rights of garment workers in the Ready-Made Garment (RMG) sector, with a specific focus on factories located in Gazipur district. The research adopts a mixed-method approach, combining quantitative survey data and qualitative insights from worker experiences. The findings reveal that while the RMG sector significantly contributes to economic growth and employment generation, workers face numerous challenges, including long working hours, low wages, inadequate workplace safety, and limited labor rights protection. Gender-based vulnerabilities further intensify these issues, particularly for female workers. The study also identifies gaps between existing labor laws and their practical implementation. Based on the findings, the research proposes practical recommendations to improve working conditions, strengthen labor rights enforcement, and promote worker well-being. Overall, the study highlights the need for collaborative efforts among stakeholders to ensure sustainable and ethical development within the garment industry.

Keywords

Ready-Made Garment (RMG), Working Conditions, Labor Rights, Wage Satisfaction, Workplace Safety, Gender Vulnerability, Gazipur, Bangladesh.

Abstrakt

Tato studie zkoumá pracovní podmínky a pracovní práva zaměstnanců v sektoru hotové konfekce (Ready-Made Garment – RMG), se zvláštním zaměřením na továrny nacházející se v okrese Gazipur. Výzkum využívá smíšený metodologický přístup, který kombinuje kvantitativní data ze šetření s kvalitativními poznatky vycházejícími ze zkušeností pracovníků. Zjištění ukazují, že ačkoli sektor RMG významně přispívá k hospodářskému růstu a tvorbě pracovních míst, pracovníci čelí řadě problémů, včetně dlouhé pracovní doby, nízkých mezd, nedostatečné bezpečnosti na pracovišti a omezené ochrany pracovních práv. Genderově podmíněné zranitelnosti tyto problémy dále prohlubují, zejména u ženských pracovníků. Studie rovněž identifikuje mezery mezi existující legislativou v oblasti pracovního práva a jejím praktickým uplatňováním. Na základě zjištění studie navrhuje konkrétní doporučení ke zlepšení pracovních podmínek, posílení prosazování pracovních práv a podpoře dobrých životních podmínek pracovníků. Celkově studie zdůrazňuje potřebu spolupráce mezi relevantními aktéry s cílem zajistit udržitelný a etický rozvoj oděvního průmyslu.

Klíčová slova:

Ready-Made Garment (RMG), pracovní podmínky, pracovní práva, spokojenost se mzdou, bezpečnost na pracovišti, genderová zranitelnost, Gazipur, Bangladéš

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List Of Abbreviations

RMG – Ready-Made Garment

HR – Human Resource

GDP – Gross Domestic Product

CSR – Corporate Social Responsibility

ILO – International Labour Organization

NGO – Non-Governmental Organization

OSH – Occupational Safety and Health

WAI – Work Ability Index

SD – Standard Deviation

HRM – Human Resource Management

BLA – Bangladesh Labour Act

EPZ – Export Processing Zone

EU – European Union

USA – United States of America

QC – Quality Control

PPE – Personal Protective Equipment

CHAPTER 1: INTRODUCTION

1.1 Background of the Study

The province of Bangladesh relies on the Ready-Made Garment (RMG) industry which is considered to be the backbone of the economy and determining factor in the industrialization, employment, and exports of the nation. The garment industry has evolved at a very high rate since the late 1970s making Bangladesh one of the largest exporters of apparel in the world. Bangladesh today is the second longest garment exporter after China who are also the suppliers of clothes to the leading international brands in Europe, North America and other areas. The industries contribute to over 80 percent of the overall export revenue of the country and, in terms of labour, the four million workers mostly women, work there (Shajahan et al., 2021).

Such fast development has seen great economic impacts such as alleviation of poverty, urbanization and women entering the workforce. But in parallel to these success stories, the RMG industry has as well gained worldwide recognition due to serious issues pertaining to poor working conditions, abuse of labor rights, work safety and welfare of the labor market. The recurring industrial accidents, including building collapses and fires, have revealed fundamental structural issues with the safety management in factories, their enforcement, and the owner liability (Islam et al., 2022; Basirulla and Rahman, 2024).

One of the major industrial centres of the garment industry in Bangladesh is Gazipur district which is situated near Dhaka. In the region, there are thousands of clothing manufacturing plants which employ hundreds of thousands of workers. Due to the high density of factories and workers, Gazipur also became the location of numerous labor conflicts, protests and safety accidents. Researchers have found that despite the positive changes observed in the aspects of health and hygiene, as well as safety, workers in Gazipur continue to struggle with severe cases of prolonged work hours, underpayment, job insecurity, and access to labor rights (Khanom et al., 2022).

Labor rights do not just encompass physical safety, but also fair pay, fair working hours, right to association, employment security, right of healthcare, maternity leave and dignity in the workplace. Most of these rights are either poorly enforced or ambiguous in the Bangladeshi RMG industry, although there is a national labor law and global labor standards (Uddin et al., 2023).

Consequently, the industry strives to be an economic growth engine but, in many instances, it can attain this goal at the expense of workers wellbeing and dignity.

1.2 Research Problem Statement

The overarching issue that this paper will examine is that, regardless of the economic success of Bangladesh to date and the presence of labor laws and labor compliance measures, the garment workers, especially those in Gazipur, still face unsafe working conditions, lack of labor rights protection and high vulnerability rates.

This is in contrast to the contradictory global perception of the factories which are considered compliant and the actual life of workers. This paper will attempt to investigate this hypocrisy and provide explanations of the same by systematically researching the working conditions and the labor rights practices of the Gazipur garment industry. Key issues identified in the garments industry in Gazipur include unsafe factory conditions, poor health and hygiene facilities, long working hours, low wages, gender-based vulnerability, and fragile labor rights protection (Figure 1)

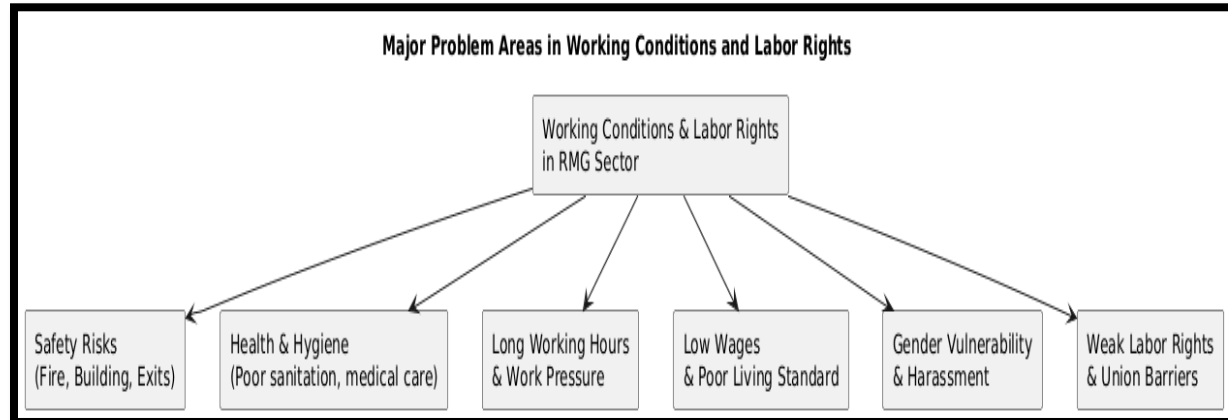


Figure 1:Key Problem Areas in Working Conditions and Labor Rights

Source: Author

Table 1 below presents the key challenges affecting working conditions and labor rights in Bangladesh's Ready-Made Garment (RMG) sector. The findings show that workplace safety remains a serious concern, with risks such as fire hazards, blocked exits, and inadequate emergency systems, exposing workers to potential accidents. Health and hygiene conditions are also poor, as

many factories lack proper sanitation and sufficient medical facilities, negatively impacting workers' well-being.

The table further indicates that excessive working hours and high work pressure are common, with overtime often becoming a necessity rather than a choice. In terms of economic conditions, low wages and inadequate living standards highlight the financial vulnerability of workers despite their critical role in the industry.

Gender-related issues are particularly significant, as female workers face harassment, job insecurity, and the burden of managing both work and household responsibilities. Additionally, labor rights remain weak due to limited unionization and restricted worker voice, preventing employees from effectively addressing grievances.

Table 1: Major Working Conditions and Labor Rights Problems in Bangladesh's RMG Sector

Issue Area	Key Problems	Supporting Studies
Workplace safety	Fire hazards, blocked exits, poor emergency systems	Islam et al. (2022); Basirulla & Rahman (2024)
Health and hygiene	Poor sanitation, limited medical facilities	Khanom et al. (2022)
Working hours	Excessive overtime, work pressure	Alam et al. (2023)
Wages and benefits	Low wages, inadequate living standards	Haque et al. (2023)
Gender vulnerability	Harassment, job insecurity, double workload	Sharmin & Manan (2022); Zohra et al. (2025)
Labor rights	Weak unionization, limited voice of workers	Hossain & Akter (2022); Uddin et al. (2023)

Source: Author

Overall, the table emphasizes that despite the economic success of the RMG sector, workers continue to face multiple structural and social challenges that affect their safety, rights, and quality of life.

1.3 Objectives of the Study

The primary objectives of this study are as follows:

1. To examine the existing working conditions in garment factories located in the Gazipur district.
2. To assess the status of labor rights practices, including wages, working hours, workplace safety, and freedom of association within these factories.
3. To identify the key issues and challenges faced by garment workers in their daily working environments.
4. To analyze worker vulnerability, with particular emphasis on gender-related aspects of labor conditions in the garment industry.
5. To evaluate the impact of current working conditions on workers' health, well-being, and productivity.
6. To propose practical recommendations for improving working conditions and strengthening the protection of labor rights in the garment sector.

1.4 Research Questions

The study is guided by the following research questions:

1. What are the prevailing working conditions in garment factories located in Gazipur district?
2. To what extent are labor rights exercised, protected, and respected within these factories?
3. What key risks are faced by workers, including structural weaknesses and common exploitative practices?
4. How do these working conditions affect the physical health, mental well-being, and overall work capacity of garment workers?

5. What measures or interventions can be undertaken by stakeholders (e.g., factory owners, policymakers, and labor organizations) to improve working conditions and protect workers' rights?

1.5 Significance of the Study

This research work is relevant in a number of ways. Theoretically, it is a source of literature in the field of labor studies, industrial relations, and development studies because it gives a case-based analysis in an integrated manner. In practice, it is useful because it allows policy-makers, factory administrators, trade unions, and foreign consumers to learn the true situation on the ground and plan more useful interventions.

Most significantly, it makes the voices and experiences of garment workers, whose labor supports one of the largest clothing industries in the world, to be visible, together with their rights and wellbeing that remain marginalized to an extent.

CHAPTER 2: LITERATURE REVIEW

2.1 Introduction

The Ready-Made Garment (RMG) sector of Bangladesh has been one of the most researched industrial sectors in the fields of labor studies, development economics, industrial relations, and human rights. The rapid expansion of this sector since the late 1970s has drawn significant academic attention due to its dual character: on the one hand, it has driven economic growth, export earnings, and women's employment; on the other hand, it has been associated with poor working conditions, weak labor rights enforcement, and recurring industrial disasters.

The RMG business is not any other line of industry in Bangladesh it is the heart of the national economy of the country. The industry has primarily low-skilled and semi-skilled laborers, most of whom are rural inhabitants and are poor on a household level. Garment work is the initial means of earning an independent income and being a part of the formal labor market to millions of women (Shajahan et al., 2021).

The sector has enabled Bangladesh to have a stable GDP growth, boost foreign exchange reserves and enhance its status in the world supply network, economically. On the social front, it has helped women to be better empowered, it has helped to postpone early marriage in some instances and the number of children of workers joining schools has also been on the increase. Nevertheless, these beneficial impacts are accompanied by harsh social and human expenditures.

The literature review serves three purposes. First, it establishes the theoretical and empirical background of the study. Second, it identifies dominant themes, debates, and gaps within existing research. Third, it justifies the need for a localized case study of Gazipur district by highlighting inconsistencies between compliance narratives and workers lived realities.

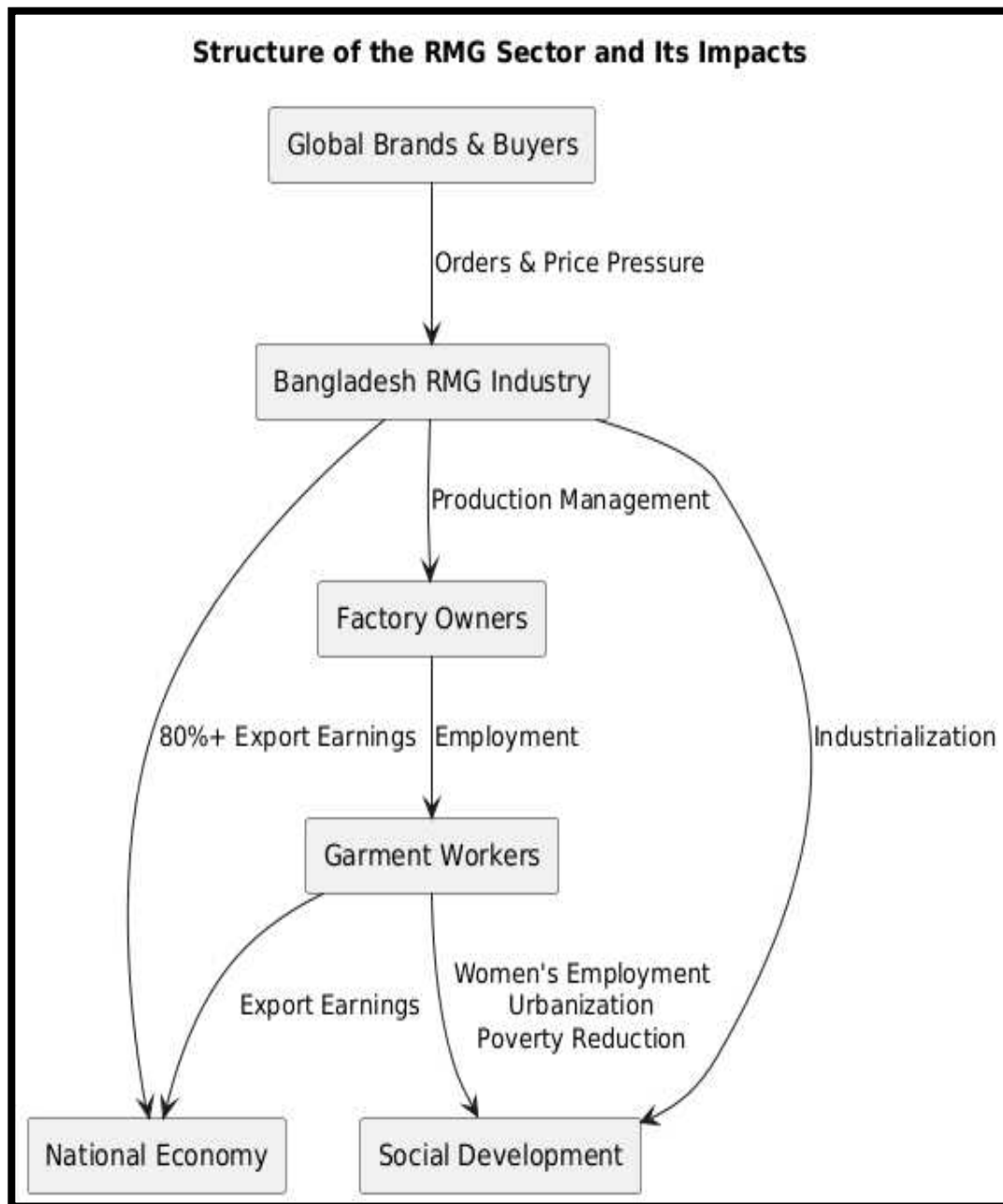


Figure 2: Structure of Bangladesh's RMG Sector & Its Impacts

Source: Author

The structural relationships within the Ready-Made Garment (RMG) sector and its broader economic and social impacts are illustrated in Figure 2, which highlights the flow from global buyers to garment workers and their contribution to national and social development

Table 2 highlights the significant contribution of the Ready-Made Garment (RMG) sector to Bangladesh's economy and employment structure.

Table 2: Economic and Employment Importance of the RMG Sector in Bangladesh

Indicator	Current Situation	Significance
Contribution to export earnings	Over 80% of total exports	Backbone of national economy
Global position	2nd largest garment exporter after China	Strong position in global apparel market
Number of factories	4,000+ factories	Large industrial base
Total employment	Over 4 million workers	Largest industrial employer
Female workforce share	60–65%	Major role in women employment
Main industrial zones	Gazipur, Dhaka, Narayanganj, Chattogram	Gazipur is one of the biggest hubs

Source: Author

Table 2 highlights the significant contribution of the Ready-Made Garment (RMG) sector to Bangladesh's economy and employment structure. The sector accounts for over 80% of total export earnings, making it the backbone of the national economy and a major source of foreign exchange. Bangladesh holds the position of the second-largest garment exporter globally after China, indicating its strong presence in the international apparel market.

The industry is supported by more than 4,000 factories, reflecting a large and well-established industrial base. It provides employment to over 4 million workers, making it the largest industrial employer in the country. A notable feature of the sector is the high participation of women, who constitute approximately 60–65% of the workforce, contributing significantly to women's economic empowerment and social development.

Additionally, major industrial zones such as Gazipur, Dhaka, Narayanganj, and Chattogram serve as key production hubs, with Gazipur being one of the most prominent centers. Overall, the table demonstrates that the RMG sector plays a vital role in economic growth, employment generation, and social transformation in Bangladesh.

2.2 Overview of Working Conditions in the RMG Sector

Garment factories in Bangladesh have received wide national and international publicity on the issue of working conditions. Working conditions refer to physical conditions (which are the ventilation, lighting, safety equipment and structure of the building), organizational conditions (working hours, workload, rest breaks etc.), and social conditions (how the supervisors treat the worker and whether the worker has a sense of usual job security and dignity at the workplace).

2.3 Conceptual Understanding of Working Conditions

Working conditions broadly refer to the physical, organizational, psychological, and social environment in which work is performed. In the context of labor-intensive industries such as garments, working conditions include factory infrastructure, ventilation, lighting, safety equipment, working hours, wage structures, workload intensity, supervision style, and access to welfare facilities (Islam, 2019).

Islam (2019) argues that working conditions in the Bangladeshi RMG sector must be understood through an intersectional lens, as they are shaped by gender, class, migration status, and global supply chain pressures. Studies consistently indicate that poor working conditions are not isolated issues but systemic outcomes of cost-driven production models and weak regulatory enforcement.

Ahmed and Chowdhury (2025) emphasize that working environment quality has a direct relationship with employee productivity and performance. However, in the RMG sector, productivity targets often override concerns for occupational health and safety, resulting in long working hours, fatigue, and declining worker well-being.

2.4 Physical Working Environment and Occupational Safety

2.4.1 Factory Infrastructure and Safety Hazards

A significant body of literature highlights unsafe factory infrastructure as a defining characteristic of Bangladesh's garment industry. Industrial accidents such as fires and building collapses have repeatedly exposed severe safety deficiencies. Islam et al. (2022) identify faulty electrical wiring, locked exits, overcrowded floors, and lack of emergency preparedness as common safety hazards across factories.

Basirulla and Rahman (2024) trace the origins of deadly industrial incidents to a historical neglect of safety standards, weak inspections, and owner resistance to compliance due to cost concerns. Despite post-disaster reforms, safety improvements remain uneven, particularly in subcontracting factories located in industrial clusters like Gazipur.

2.4.2 Health, Hygiene, and Medical Facilities

Beyond catastrophic accidents, everyday occupational health risks are widely documented. Khanom et al. (2022) find that while some factories have improved hygiene and cleanliness, access to medical facilities, rest areas, and adequate sanitation remains insufficient. Workers frequently report musculoskeletal pain, eye strain, headaches, and respiratory issues due to prolonged sitting, repetitive motion, and poor ventilation.

Zohra et al. (2025) further demonstrate that extended working hours and physically demanding tasks significantly reduce work ability among female workers, increasing long-term health risks. These findings suggest that health issues are structurally embedded in production practices rather than accidental occurrences.

Several physical working conditions are faced by the workers of RMG sector such as safety risks, poor hygiene and sanitation, limited medical facilities, and poor ventilation and lighting. Table 3 summarises these issues.

Table 3: Key Dimensions of Physical Working Conditions in Bangladesh’s RMG Sector

Dimension	Common Issues Identified	Supporting Literature
Factory safety	Fire hazards, blocked exits, poor wiring	Islam et al. (2022); Basirulla & Rahman (2024)
Hygiene & sanitation	Inadequate toilets, poor cleanliness	Khanom et al. (2022)
Medical facilities	Limited access to healthcare	Zohra et al. (2025)
Ventilation & lighting	Poor air circulation, eye strain	Islam (2019)

Source: Author

2.4.3 Ergonomic Conditions and Workstation Design

Ergonomic conditions constitute an important yet often overlooked dimension of occupational safety in the Ready-Made Garment (RMG) sector. Ergonomics refers to the design of workstations, tools, and tasks in a manner that fits workers’ physical capabilities and limitations. In garment factories, workers typically perform repetitive tasks such as sewing, cutting, ironing, and packing for prolonged periods, often while seated or standing in constrained postures. Poor ergonomic design has been widely associated with musculoskeletal disorders, chronic pain, and long-term physical disability among garment workers.

Islam (2019) highlights those sewing operators frequently work on poorly designed chairs and tables that do not support proper posture, leading to back pain, neck strain, and shoulder injuries. The absence of adjustable seating and work surfaces forces workers to adapt their bodies to the machines rather than the machines being adapted to the workers. Over time, this mismatch significantly increases the risk of repetitive strain injuries.

Zohra et al. (2025) provide empirical evidence that female garment workers suffer disproportionately from reduced work ability due to physically demanding tasks and inadequate ergonomic support. Their study demonstrates a strong association between long working hours, static postures, and declining physical health, particularly among older and long-serving workers.

These health issues not only affect individual well-being but also reduce productivity and increase absenteeism.

Despite the seriousness of ergonomic risks, they receive limited attention in factory inspections and compliance audits, which tend to prioritize structural safety and fire prevention. Ahmed and Chowdhury (2025) argue that neglecting ergonomic design undermines the sustainability of the workforce and contributes to high labor turnover. Therefore, improving ergonomic conditions should be recognized as a core component of occupational safety rather than a secondary concern.

2.4.4 Emergency Preparedness, Training, and Safety Awareness

Emergency preparedness and safety awareness are critical components of occupational safety, particularly in an industry with a history of fatal accidents. Emergency preparedness includes the availability of fire drills, evacuation plans, emergency exits, alarm systems, and worker training on emergency response procedures. The literature consistently indicates that deficiencies in these areas significantly increase the severity of industrial accidents in the RMG sector.

Islam et al. (2022) report that although many factories display emergency exit signs and install fire equipment to meet compliance requirements, workers often lack proper training on how to respond during emergencies. Fire drills are either irregular or conducted superficially, limiting their effectiveness during real incidents. As a result, panic and confusion during emergencies frequently lead to injuries and loss of life.

Basirulla and Rahman (2024) emphasize that the absence of a safety culture within factories exacerbates occupational risks. Safety measures are often treated as external obligations imposed by regulators or buyers rather than internalized as a shared responsibility between management and workers. This approach discourages worker participation in safety practices and reduces awareness of potential hazards.

Furthermore, Ashadullah (2021) notes that many workers, particularly new and migrant employees, are not adequately informed about emergency procedures, evacuation routes, or the use of fire-fighting equipment. Language barriers, low literacy levels, and high labor turnover further weaken safety communication. These challenges are especially pronounced in industrial zones like Gazipur, where factories operate at high capacity with frequent workforce changes.

Developing effective emergency preparedness requires not only physical infrastructure but also continuous training, worker engagement, and transparent communication. Without these elements, compliance-based safety measures remain symbolic and fail to protect workers in critical situations.

2.5 Working Hours, Wages, and Labor Intensity

2.5.1 Long Working Hours and Overtime Practices

Excessive working hours are among the most consistently reported problems in the RMG sector. Although Bangladesh labor law prescribes limits on daily and weekly working hours, multiple studies reveal systematic violations. Alam et al. (2023) note that overtime is often compulsory rather than voluntary, especially during peak production seasons.

Workers frequently work 10–12 hours per day, six to seven days a week, leading to physical exhaustion and mental stress. Such practices are intensified by global buyer pressure for low-cost and fast delivery, which translates into unrealistic production targets at the factory level (Uddin et al., 2023).

2.5.2 Wages and Living Standards

Low wages remain a core issue despite periodic minimum wage revisions. Haque et al. (2023) link low garment wages to poor household nutrition, particularly among workers' children. Their findings suggest that garment employment does not guarantee a decent standard of living, reinforcing cycles of poverty and vulnerability.

Nova et al. (2023) argue that wage exploitation persists due to workers' weak bargaining power and fear of job loss. Even when wages comply with legal minimums, they often fail to meet living wage standards, undermining workers' economic security. These work and wage related issues are summarised in table 4 below.

Table 4: Wage and Working Hour Issues in the RMG Sector

Aspect	Observed Practice	Literature Evidence
Daily working hours	10–12 hours common	Alam et al. (2023)
Overtime payment	Often delayed or unpaid	Nova et al. (2023)
Wage adequacy	Below living wage	Haque et al. (2023)
Job security	High turnover, fear of dismissal	Uddin et al. (2023)

Source: Author

2.6 Labor Rights and Legal Framework

Bangladesh has a set system of legislation that is meant to take care of the rights of workers, such as the Bangladesh Labor Act and several labor regulations and amendments. These laws include: minimum wages, working hours, payment of overtime, leaves, maternity benefits, and the right to join trade union

2.6.1 National Labor Laws and Compliance

Bangladesh has a comprehensive labor law framework covering minimum wages, working hours, maternity benefits, and freedom of association. However, enforcement remains weak. Hasan (2019) highlights gaps between legal provisions and actual implementation, especially in privately owned garment factories.

Ashadullah (2021) finds that compliance audits often focus on documentation rather than real practices, allowing factories to present a façade of legality while continuing exploitative practices.

2.6.2 Trade Unions and Freedom of Association

Trade unionization in the RMG sector is severely constrained. Hossain and Akter (2022) document intimidation, administrative barriers, and dismissal of union leaders as common strategies used to suppress collective action. As a result, workers lack effective mechanisms to voice grievances.

Uddin et al. (2023) situate this issue within global supply chains, arguing that international brands indirectly benefit from weak labor rights enforcement while distancing themselves from responsibility. The realities of labor rights and its challenges are mentioned in Table 5 below.

Table 5: Labor Rights Enforcement Challenges

Labor Right	Legal Status	Practical Reality	Key Studies
Minimum wage	Legally mandated	Often inadequate	Haque et al. (2023)
Overtime regulation	Defined by law	Frequently violated	Alam et al. (2023)
Unionization	Legal right	Actively restricted	Hossain & Akter (2022)
Job security	Protected	Highly unstable	Uddin et al. (2023)

Source: Author

2.6.3 Maternity Rights, Social Protection, and Welfare Provisions

Maternity rights and social protection mechanisms are essential components of labor rights, particularly in an industry where women constitute the majority of the workforce. Bangladesh labor law provides for maternity leave, maternity benefits, and certain welfare provisions such as childcare facilities and health services. However, existing literature indicates a substantial gap between legal entitlements and actual practices within the Ready-Made Garment (RMG) sector.

Hasan (2019) observes that although maternity benefits are legally mandated, many female garment workers are either unaware of these rights or unable to claim them due to fear of job loss and discrimination. In some cases, workers are pressured to resign upon becoming pregnant or are denied paid maternity leave altogether. Such practices undermine both labor rights and women's reproductive health.

Sharmin and Manan (2022) further report that the absence of functional childcare facilities forces many female workers to leave infants in unsafe conditions or discontinue employment after childbirth. This lack of institutional support reinforces economic insecurity and perpetuates gender inequality within the workplace. Sultana (2025) also documents instances of verbal harassment and coercion faced by pregnant workers, highlighting the intersection between gender-based violence and labor rights violations.

Beyond maternity protection, social welfare provisions such as health insurance, sick leave, and compensation for workplace injuries remain limited. Nova et al. (2023) argue that the lack of comprehensive social protection exposes garment workers to severe financial risk in cases of illness, injury, or unemployment. Consequently, labor rights in the RMG sector remain narrowly

defined and inadequately enforced, failing to address workers' broader social and economic vulnerabilities.

2.6.4 Monitoring, Compliance Mechanisms, and Accountability

Monitoring and compliance mechanisms play a central role in translating labor laws into actual workplace practices. In Bangladesh's RMG sector, compliance is primarily enforced through a combination of government inspections, buyer-led audits, and international safety initiatives. However, the effectiveness of these mechanisms has been widely questioned in the literature.

Ashadullah (2021) argues that compliance assessments often focus on visible indicators such as documentation, signage, and physical infrastructure, while overlooking less visible but equally important issues such as excessive overtime, harassment, and denial of labor rights. This creates a compliance culture driven by appearances rather than substantive improvements in workers' lives.

Uddin et al. (2023) frame this problem within the concept of "irresponsible capitalism," where global brands rely on audit-based systems that shift responsibility onto suppliers without addressing structural power imbalances. As a result, factory owners may comply during inspections while reverting to exploitative practices once audits are completed.

Tarafder (2024) highlights the importance of inclusive governance in strengthening accountability. The study suggests that involving workers in monitoring processes, encouraging transparent grievance mechanisms, and protecting whistle-blowers can enhance compliance outcomes. However, such participatory approaches remain limited in practice, particularly in industrial zones like Gazipur where factories operate under intense production pressure.

Overall, the literature indicates that without strong state enforcement, worker participation, and global accountability, compliance mechanisms alone are insufficient to ensure labor rights protection. This underscores the need for a more holistic and enforceable governance framework within the RMG sector.

2.7 Gender Dimension and Worker Vulnerability

The nature of the garment industry is that of female dominance, which is one of the unique characteristics of the sector in Bangladesh. Approximately 60-65 percent of the total population of

workers are women (Shajahan et al., 2021). This makes significant consequences on empowerment and vulnerability.

2.7.1 Female Workforce Participation

Women constitute the majority of garment workers in Bangladesh. Shajahan et al. (2021) highlight that the RMG sector has been instrumental in bringing women into the formal labor force. However, this participation is often characterized by low-skilled, low-paid, and insecure jobs.

Asadullah and Talukder (2019) describe a “paradox of contentment,” where female workers report satisfaction despite objectively poor conditions, largely due to limited alternatives and social constraints.

2.7.2 Gendered Vulnerabilities

Sharmin and Manan (2022) provide qualitative evidence of multiple vulnerabilities faced by female workers, including harassment, lack of childcare, and double workloads combining factory work and domestic responsibilities. Sultana (2025) further documents incidents of workplace violence, verbal abuse, and coercion.

Fakhoury (2019) offers an ecofeminist perspective, arguing that the exploitation of female labor in the garment industry mirrors broader patterns of social and environmental injustice.

2.7.3 Migration Status, Housing Insecurity, and Gendered Vulnerability

A large proportion of female garment workers in Bangladesh are internal migrants who relocate from rural areas to industrial hubs such as Gazipur in search of employment. Migration status significantly intensifies worker vulnerability, particularly for women, by separating them from traditional social support systems and exposing them to precarious living and working conditions.

Wahid et al. (2020) highlight that female migrant garment workers in Gazipur often reside in overcrowded, poorly constructed rental housing with inadequate sanitation, ventilation, and security. Such living conditions compound workplace stress and adversely affect physical and mental health. For many women, unsafe housing environments increase exposure to harassment, theft, and violence, both within and outside the workplace.

Faisal (2025) further argues that climate-induced migration has contributed to a growing influx of vulnerable workers into the RMG sector. Many female migrants enter garment employment as a survival strategy rather than a choice, limiting their bargaining power and increasing acceptance of exploitative conditions. This dependency on factory income makes women particularly reluctant to report abuse or labor rights violations.

Sharmin and Manan (2022) observe that migrant female workers face additional challenges related to social isolation and lack of access to healthcare and childcare facilities. These factors deepen economic insecurity and reinforce gendered inequalities, demonstrating that worker vulnerability extends beyond factory floors into workers' everyday living environments.

2.8 Global Supply Chains and Irresponsible Capitalism

The role of global buyers and brands is a central theme in recent literature. Uddin et al. (2023) argue that global supply chains create asymmetric power relations where risks are transferred to local workers while profits are captured by multinational corporations.

Das and Shafiquzzaman (2020) note that sustainability initiatives are often driven by reputational concerns rather than genuine commitment to worker welfare. Munna (2023) similarly finds that sustainable supply chain practices are unevenly implemented, particularly among smaller factories in Gazipur.

2.8.1 Buyer Power, Price Pressure, and Cost-Cutting Practices

One of the most critical dynamics shaping labor conditions in Bangladesh's Ready-Made Garment (RMG) sector is the unequal power relationship between global buyers and local suppliers. International brands and retailers exercise significant control over pricing, production timelines, and quality standards, while suppliers operate in a highly competitive environment with limited bargaining power. This imbalance has direct implications for working conditions and labor rights at the factory level.

Uddin et al. (2023) argue that intense buyer-driven price competition compels factory owners to minimize production costs in order to secure and retain contracts. As labor constitutes one of the largest controllable costs, cost-cutting strategies are frequently implemented through wage

suppression, excessive overtime, and reduction of welfare benefits. These practices allow factories to meet buyer demands while shifting the burden of efficiency onto workers.

Das and Shafiquzzaman (2020) further explain that short lead times imposed by buyers encourage suppliers to increase work intensity rather than invest in additional labor or infrastructure. As a result, workers are required to meet high production targets under significant time pressure, often at the expense of safety and health. This production model normalizes labor exploitation as an operational necessity rather than an ethical violation.

Nova et al. (2023) emphasize that such buyer-induced cost pressures weaken the effectiveness of national labor laws, as factory owners prioritize commercial survival over legal compliance. Consequently, global buyer practices play a central role in sustaining exploitative labor conditions within the RMG supply chain.

2.8.2 Corporate Social Responsibility, Auditing Limitations, and Symbolic Compliance

Corporate Social Responsibility (CSR) initiatives and third-party auditing systems are commonly promoted as solutions to labor rights violations in global supply chains. In Bangladesh's RMG sector, CSR programs include codes of conduct, social compliance audits, and factory certification schemes. However, the literature increasingly questions the effectiveness of these mechanisms in delivering meaningful improvements for workers.

Ashadullah (2021) notes that many compliance audits are predictable and scheduled in advance, allowing factories to temporarily alter practices to meet audit requirements. This results in what is often referred to as "symbolic compliance," where factories appear compliant on paper while continuing exploitative practices in everyday operations.

Uddin et al. (2023) argue that CSR frameworks often prioritize brand reputation management over worker empowerment. Audits typically exclude worker participation and fail to address issues such as harassment, forced overtime, and suppression of trade unions. As a result, CSR initiatives may inadvertently legitimize poor labor practices by creating an illusion of ethical production.

Tarafder (2024) highlights that without binding accountability mechanisms, CSR remains voluntary and weakly enforced. The absence of legal consequences for non-compliance allows

both brands and suppliers to evade responsibility. This gap between ethical rhetoric and practical outcomes reinforces patterns of irresponsible capitalism within the global garment supply chain.

Overall, the literature suggests that CSR and auditing, in their current forms, are insufficient to protect labor rights. Meaningful reform requires shifting from voluntary compliance toward enforceable obligations shared across global supply chains.

2.9 Governance, Technology, and Emerging Trends

Recent studies explore governance reforms and technological interventions. Tarafder (2024) emphasizes inclusive governance as a pathway to employee well-being, while Sarker (2024) highlights the role of technology in improving supply chain efficiency. However, these studies caution that technological advancement alone cannot resolve labor rights issues without structural reforms.

Faisal (2025) introduces climate-induced migration as an emerging factor shaping the RMG workforce, adding another layer of vulnerability to already marginalized workers.

In addition to governance reforms and technological advancement, recent literature highlights the growing importance of transparency and data-driven monitoring in improving labor conditions within the RMG sector. Digital wage payment systems, biometric attendance tracking, and electronic production monitoring have been introduced in some factories to reduce wage manipulation and improve record accuracy (Tarafder, 2024). While these technologies have the potential to enhance accountability, their effectiveness largely depends on how they are implemented and governed.

Sarker (2024) notes that technological innovations often prioritize supply chain efficiency and cost reduction rather than worker welfare. Without appropriate regulatory oversight, technology may inadvertently intensify labor exploitation by enabling closer surveillance and increased work pressure. Similarly, Munna (2023) argues that sustainability-oriented technologies remain unevenly distributed, with smaller factories in industrial zones such as Gazipur lacking the financial capacity to adopt advanced systems.

Furthermore, Faisal (2025) emphasizes that emerging challenges such as climate-induced migration and urban congestion require integrated governance responses that extend beyond

factory-level interventions. These trends suggest that governance and technology must be aligned with inclusive labor policies to ensure that innovation contributes to decent work rather than reinforcing existing inequalities.

2.10 Research Gaps Identified

Despite extensive research, several gaps remain:

1. Limited district-level case studies focusing specifically on Gazipur
2. Overreliance on compliance reports rather than worker experiences
3. Insufficient integration of gender, health, and labor rights perspectives
4. Weak linkage between global supply chain dynamics and local realities

These gaps justify the present study's focus on Gazipur district and its mixed-method approach.

2.11 Chapter Summary

This chapter reviewed the existing literature on working conditions and labor rights in Bangladesh's RMG sector. The literature reveals persistent problems related to safety, wages, working hours, labor rights enforcement, and gender vulnerability, despite legal frameworks and compliance initiatives. Global supply chain pressures and weak governance structures exacerbate these issues, particularly in industrial hubs such as Gazipur. The identified gaps underscore the need for a localized, worker-centered investigation, which is undertaken in the subsequent chapters.

CHAPTER 3: METHODOLOGY

3.1 Introduction

As introduced in this chapter, the research methodology used was to study the working conditions and labour rights of workers in the Ready-Made Garment (RMG) industry in Bangladesh. The area of the analysis is the Gazipur District that is among the most marked industrial regions in the nation. The chapter provides information on the research design, philosophical position, methods of data collection, sample plan, methods of analytical processes, research tools, ethical issues, and constraints related to the research. The RMG industry has turned out to be the support of the Bangladesh economy and it plays a major role in earning export and also in earning job. The sector contains millions of workers, and much of them, according to the previous study, are rural women (Hossain and Alam, 2021). Although the industry has positively impacted the economy, issues have been raised about working conditions, occupational safety, wage system as well as compliance to labour rights in the garment factories. The overtime work, inaccessibility to employee labour rights protection, the problem of safety at the workplace, and gender inequity in the factories have been emphasised in a number of international events and academic studies (Mahmood et al., 2021). It has also been indicated by researchers that social and emotional wellbeing of garment workers, especially the female workers, is closely related to their working conditions and organisational policies (Sultana et al., 2025). There is a need to have the empirical research on these issues at the factory level where the working conditions and labour rights policies are enacted. This is why; the current study is done in a form of a case study that entails two to three garment factories in Gazipur District. This is a mixed-method research methodology based on quantitative and qualitative research. The quantitative information is gained by use of structured surveys, where the garment workers are interviewed, the condition of the factories observed, and the human resource (HR) policies and compliance documentation reviewed. Statistical methods and thematic analysis of the data gathered are compared and the results are outlined in the form of tables, figures and quotes of interviews. The outcomes are also compared with the national labour laws and available academic literature so as to determine gaps and conflicting issues with regard to labour rights realisation.

3.2 Research Philosophy

Research philosophy is a collection of belief, which determines how knowledge should be produced and interpreted in a research study. The philosophy that I have chosen to use in the study is pragmatism, which focuses more on practical solutions to the research problems and is open to the combination of quantitative and qualitative research approaches. The labour rights and working conditions in the garment industry are a complicated and multidimensional issue. On the one hand the working conditions including the rate of wages, hours of working, and safety can be quantitatively measured. Conversely, employee experiences, sense of equitability and emotional state should be interpreted qualitatively. The pragmatic philosophy thus enables the researcher to mix various approaches in the bid to develop a holistic view of the research problem. Mixed research methods have also been employed in the previous research that investigated the labour practises in Bangladeshi garment industry. As an example, Bosman et al. (2019) organised a systematic review of the gender gap and structural issues of women employees in the garment industry. Likewise, Syed et al. (2024) tested the effect of the labour welfare on the outcomes of workers working in the garment supply chain through the synthesis of the empirical analysis and policy evaluation. These works show that both statistical analysis and qualitative data are necessary to comprehend the nature of labour rights and the working conditions of a certain workplace. The pragmatic approach to philosophy used in this study hence justified the incorporation of various sources of data, as well as allowed the researcher to acknowledge the research questions in a practical and holistic way.

3.3 Research Approach

The research is conducted in a deductive research method; it encompasses formulating research questions and hypotheses using the already existing theories and literature and then the testing is carried out by undergoing empirical research. The deductive strategy commences with theoretical illumination on the basis of scholarly literature in the area of labour rights, occupational safety, and work welfare. As an illustration, the earlier studies have suggested that the adherence to the workplace safety measures and labour laws may work wonders in enhancing the wellbeing and productivity of workers (Mahmood et al., 2021). In other investigations, it has been highlighted that the organisational commitment and job satisfaction among the garment workers have increased due to the labour policies such as fair wages and health benefits (Syed et al., 2024).

Relying on these theoretical elements, the current paper will explore the hypothesis of whether labour rights policies and working practises are practical in the performance of the chosen garment factories in Gazipur District. The research examines how far the workers and factory management believe and what they actually see in working conditions in the industry by gathering and interpreting empirical data of what is expected. The deductive method will be quite suitable in this study, as the researcher will be able to contrast the findings of the empirical study with the current theoretical frameworks and legal norms. By this analogy, the study brings out gaps between the official labour policies and reality encountered by employees in the garment factories.

3.4 Research Design

3.4.1 Case Study Research Design

The study takes the case study research design as the study field is two to three ready-made garment factories in Gazipur District, Bangladesh. Case study method allows the researcher to enquire the working condition and the labour rights in a given organisational situation. This design would especially be appropriate in research that seeks to study the reality of studies regarding workplace settings and organisational practises. Focusing on a small list of factories, the researcher will be able to gather detailed data on the issues of workplace safety, wage system, and the way labour policies were applied. The case study method also enables the incorporation of various methods of data collection like interviews, observation and surveys among others to give a comprehensive view of the research issue.

3.4.2 Application in the Garment Industry Context

Case studies are well applied in social science studies where the aim is to research on complex social and organisational phenomena in their real life context. When one considers the industry of ready-made garments, the factory has quite a number of interrelated aspects such as production goals, administrative policies, labour laws and interpersonal interaction between the workers. These are determinants of the working environment of the employees. Case study method allows the researcher to see that interaction of these elements in the chosen factories. These dynamics in detail might reveal that the study could be an important contribution to the field of how labour rights in reality are implemented, as well as the daily problems encountered by the garment workers.

3.4.3 Selection of Gazipur District

The study area of Gazipur District has been chosen as the main focus of the study since it is among the most significant manufacturing districts of garment industries in Bangladesh. Garment factories are also very many in the district and produce goods that serve the local and foreign markets. Gazipur is a good place to conduct a study on working conditions and labour rights within the ready-made garment industry due to it possessing a large population of industrial workers. The density of the factories is also an advantage of having a chance to compare other workplace practise as in the same industrial setup. Consequently, the results of this research can yield valuable information on the policies regarding the general labour situation in the Bangladeshi garment sector.

3.4.4 Research Design Framework

Research design framework presents a systematic overview of a research undertaking which entails; identification of research questions to the ultimate interpretation of results. The framework incorporates a variety of sources of evidence, such as survey of workers, interviews, observational data and organisational documents, such as HR policies and compliance reports. Integrating all these types of data helps to make the research design complete since it will thoroughly analyse the working conditions and labour rights in the chosen factories. Reliability and validity of the research findings are also enhanced by the integration of various data sources and enable the researcher to cross-tabulate the data received through various participants and documents.

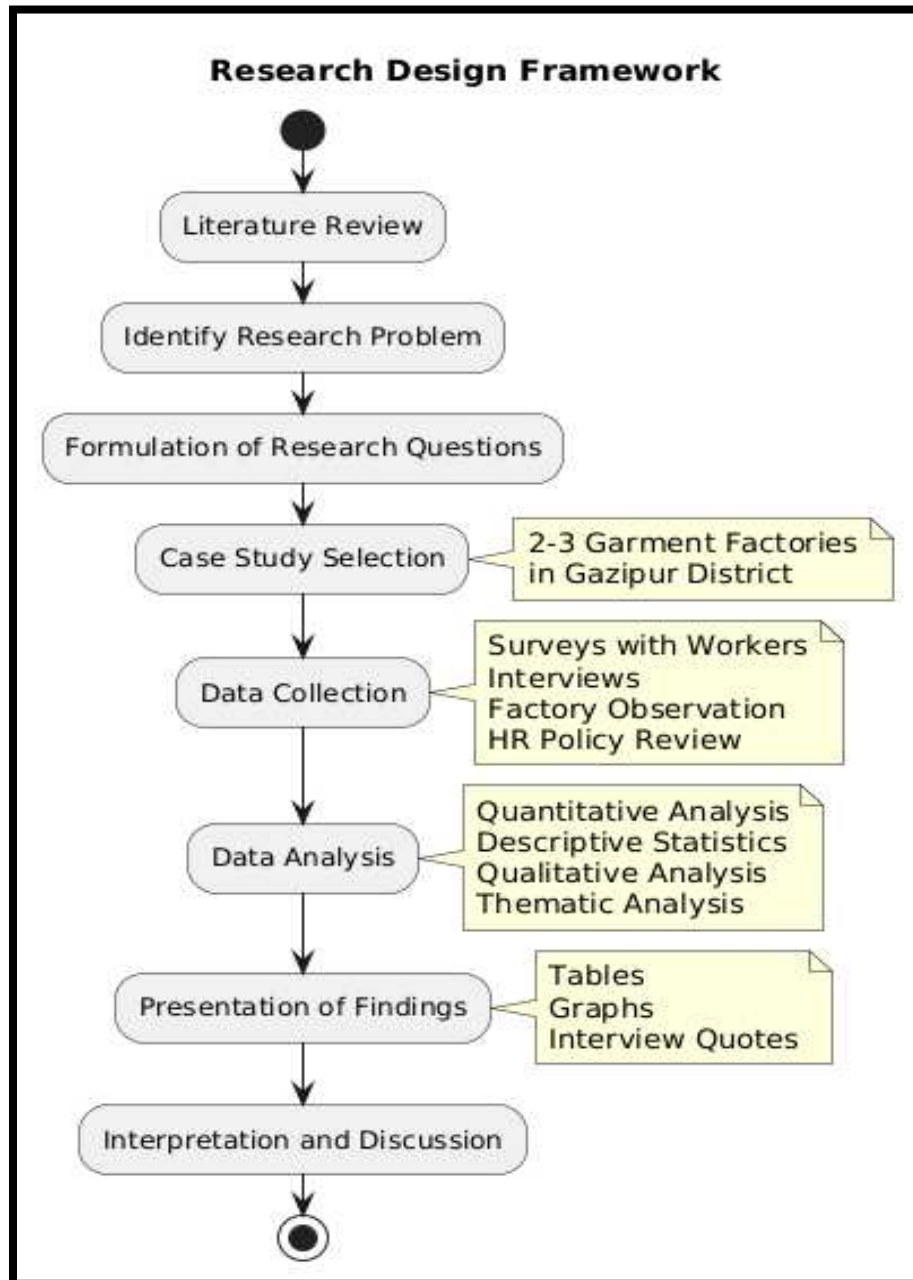


Figure 3: Research Design Framework

Source: Author

This research design allows the integration of multiple sources of evidence, which strengthens the reliability and validity of the research findings. The overall research process is illustrated in Figure

3.5 Sampling Strategy and Case Selection

This study uses two to three garment factories in Gazipur District as the subject. The factories will be chosen according to their disposition, readiness to take part in the research and the aspect of relevancy as per the objectives of the research. Choosing two or three factories gives the researcher a chance to make comparison on working conditions of various organisational settings. In the sampled factories, the employees in various departments of production are also sampled. Such departments are usually fitted with sewing, cutting, finishing and quality control. Having representatives of different departments will help the researcher to gather various views on the work practises and labour rights.

Table 6: Sample Distribution

Worker Category	Estimated Population	Sample Size
Sewing workers	200	40
Cutting workers	100	20
Finishing workers	120	25
Supervisors and managers	40	15
Total respondents	460	100

Source: Author

Overall estimated population size is four hundred and sixty where the sample size of approximately one hundred respondents provides a sufficient dataset for meaningful statistical analysis while remaining manageable for field research Table 6.

3.6 Data Collection Methods

Data collection involves several complementary methods in order to capture different aspects of working conditions and labor rights within the selected garment factories.

3.6.1 Worker Surveys

Quantitative data on garment workers is collected by way of structured questionnaire. The questionnaire will cover the issue of working hours, wage level, the safety level at the working place, the level of understanding of labour rights, and the theoretical job satisfaction in general. The variables have been popularly known as major indicators of employee welfare and work

conditions. The survey queries will be modelled with answers on a Likert scale to evaluate the perception and attitudes of the workers. This format enables the researcher to get average scores and determine the trends in the responses of the workers. Survey variables are described in Table 7.

Table 7: Key Survey Variables

VARIABLE	DESCRIPTION
Working hours	Daily working hours and overtime practices
Wage satisfaction	Worker perception of salary fairness
Safety conditions	Availability of safety equipment
Labor rights awareness	Knowledge of labor laws
Worker wellbeing	Access to healthcare and welfare benefits

Source: Author

3.6.2 Worker Interviews

The semi-structured interview with the chosen workers and supervisors is performed. These interviews are qualitative in that they give us information on the experiences of the workers, their perception of the workplace conditions, and their knowledge of their labour right. According to Sultana et al. (2025), female garment workers are prone to difficulties associated with the patriarchal organisation of the workplace and emotional distress. It is an interview that allows the discussion of these issues at a deeper level, then. The interview responses are documented on written and audio records whereby the participants give consent.

3.6.3 Observation of Factory Conditions

The physical and organisational environment in the factories is analysed through observation. In visits to the factory, the researcher monitors the factory features like the ventilation, the working layouts, accessibility of the protective gear, and emergency exits as well as the workers interrelation. It is through observation that one can confirm the existence of official safety policies which are being implemented within factory premises. As pointed out by Mahmood et al. (2021), the compliance with workplace safety in garment factories is usually different between the official policy and practise.

3.6.4 Review of HR Policies and Compliance Documents

Along with primary data gathering, internal documents concerning the topic of human resource management and labour compliance along with the reviews are performed. These papers will contain employment agreement, safety protocols at workplace, HR policies as well as compliance reports, which are vetted to suit international purchasers. The practises of human resource management are also important in defining the experiences of workers and the organisational culture in garment factories (Taib, 2019). The research assesses the suitability of formal labour policies with the working conditions encountered in the field research by analysing HR policies and compliance records.

3.7 Research Instruments

Several instruments are used during the data collection process to ensure systematic documentation of research findings.

Table 8 : Research Instruments

Instrument	Purpose
Questionnaire	Collect survey data from workers
Interview guide	Structure qualitative interviews
Observation checklist	Evaluate the factory environment
Audio recording device	Document interview responses

Source: Author

These instruments enable the researcher to gather reliable and consistent data from multiple sources. Various tools have been used during the data collection process to ensure systematic documentation and research findings. The main research instruments used in the study are presented in Table 8.

3.8 Data Analysis and Presentation

After data collection, the information is analyzed using both quantitative and qualitative analytical techniques.

3.8.1 Quantitative Data Analysis

The gathered quantitative information on the worker surveys is interpreted with the help of the descriptive statistical techniques to generate the pattern and trends on the working conditions and labour rights in the chosen garment factories. The responses given by the participants are summarised using methods like frequency distribution, percentages and mean scores. These statistical tools can assist the researcher to know important questions such as working hours, wage level, safety of the work place and awareness of the labour rights by the garment workers. The statistical form of the numerical data will simplify the process of comparison of the responses that will exist within the various groups of workers and various departments. This strategy gives a clear picture of the general picture of the situation of labour in the factories under investigation.

3.8.2 Qualitative Data Analysis

Qualitative data is analysed through thematic analysis to interpolate qualitative data collected through semi-structured interviews with the workers and supervisors. This technique will entail a thorough examination of the interview transcript texts and the identification of having themes, trends, and closely occurring concerns by the participants. Thematic analysis can help the researcher use the emerging themes as to how the workers experience, perceive, and feel about the workplace practises, safety precautions, and labour rights. In the process, the research will be able to get more in-depth information that could not be observed with only quantitative data. As an example, employees can talk about such problems as working long hours, stress at work, or lack of knowledge about labour laws. It is these themes that assist in the deeper perception of the social and organisational set-up in the garment factories.

3.8.3 Data Presentation

The data analysed is organised and represented well to make it easy to discuss and interpret. The quantitative results are presented in the form of tables, charts, and graphical illustrations summarising the answer to the survey and reflecting its significance. Such visual representations allow better perception of the distribution of responses and the comparison of various variables concerning the working conditions and labour rights. Moreover, qualitative data is also established by providing selected quotes of the interview participants that contribute to the illustration of the individual experiences and opinion of workers. The range of statistical tables used, accompanied by the presence of narrative explanation and the content of the interview, makes it possible to convey the research results to the audience and facilitates the full interpretation of the data.

The findings are displayed in the form of the table and graphs and direct quotes of the interview participants. Such methods of presentation are useful in the process of making the findings clear and aid in interpreting the data. The overall data analysis process are illustrated in figure 4.

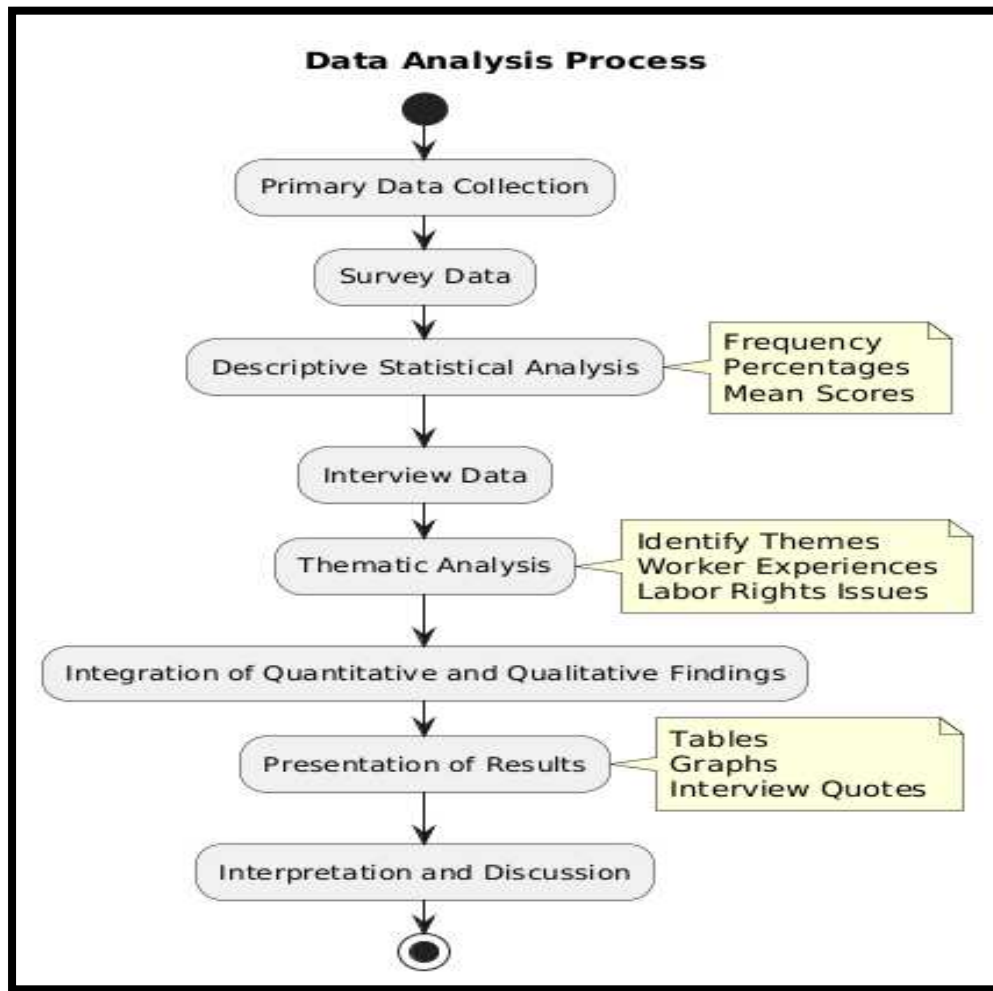


Figure 4: Data Analysis Process

Source: Author

3.9 Reliability and Validity

3.9.1 Reliability

Reliability is what can be described as the uniformity and permanence of the research findings with time and with respondents. Reliability in this study is achieved through the construction of standardised questionnaires and guidelines in conducting the interview in the collection of data. Similar questions are posed to all the responders so that the responses would be comparable in the sense that they reflect the same. Similarly, surveys, interviews, and observations are also carried out in the chosen garment factories using the same processes. It is consistent and helps to reduce mistakes and makes the results reliable. Cautiousness of data collections processes also helps in

enhancing reliability of the study and enhance transparency underpinning the researchers research methodology.

3.9.2 Validity

Validity is used to refer to the extent in which the research measures what it is supposed to measure and whether the research findings are a real reflection of the reality of working conditions and labour rights within the garment industry. Data triangulation is also used in this research to enhance the validity as it is a tool involving the gathering of information based on different sources such as data gathered by means of worker surveys questionnaires, interviews, direct observations, and post-reviewing of HR policies and compliance documents. It is through comparison and cross-checking these various sources of data that the researcher can determine whether the findings can be considered accurate and will help them determine whether there were any inconsistencies. The latter will increase the validity of the study and minimise the risk of prejudice or distortion.

3.10 Ethical Considerations

Ethical issues are equally important in research involving human subjects especially when the research is targeting a vulnerable group of workers like the workforce in the Ready-Made Garment (RMG) industry. Several ethical principles are observed keenly in this research to ascertain that rights, dignity, and safety of everyone involved in the data collection and analysis exercise are safeguarded. Research The aim and objectives of the research are explained to the workers before the actual interviews or surveys are conducted. Their use of information obtained is explained and they are informed that the information will help in getting insights about the working conditions and labour rights within the garment industry. The gay men can participate in the study as it is entirely voluntary, and the respondents are requested to give their consent informedly regarding the surveys or interview process. Employees are to be assured that their involvement will not have any impact on their work and association with the factory management. Personal data like names, factory identification number, and exact job jobs are not given in the research report so as to keep things confidential. Rather, the responses are anonymized and displayed in aggregated table, graph and summarised results.

3.11 Research Limitations

- **Limited Access to Factories:** Some garment factories can be closed or restricted by the company policy or management prerequisites. This may make the number of factories and participants to be surveyed or interviewed or observed small.
- **Employee unwillingness to join in:** There are those workers who are generally not willing to discuss the workplace issues, labour rights and practises of the management due to some form of job security or fear of being subject to punishment.
- **Small Sample Size:** The study will concentrate on a small sample of factories and respondents because of time constraints and constraints in accessibility and this could impact on the scope of data gathered.
- **Geographical Limitation:** The study is only carried out in Gazipur District. Subsequently, the results might not reflect the nature and activities of working conditions and labour rights in other garment manufacturing areas of Bangladesh.
- **Data Availability Constraints:** It is possible that only access to internal HR policies, documents of compliance and records of the organisation could be restricted and therefore could limit the extent of documentary analysis.
- **Time Constraints:** The study is performed in the scope of a relatively brief academic time, which can limit the possibility to provide field observations and longitudinal study.
- **Potential Response Bias:** There are certain participants who can give socially desirable answers in survey or interview and this will affect the accuracy of the results.

Irrespective of these setbacks, Gazipur is among the biggest garment manufacturing centres in Bangladesh. Consequently, the knowledge gained through this study remains useful and can serve useful pointers in the overall trends in working environments and labour rights in the RMG sector of the country.

3.12 Chapter Summary

In this chapter, the author offered the methodological framework proposed to discuss the working conditions and labour rights of workers working in the Ready-Made Garment (RMG) sector in Bangladesh with references to garment factories found in Gazipur District. The chapter presented research philosophy, research approach, research design, data collection methods, sampling plan,

data analysis process, research tools, ethical concerns and limitations of such a research. The study employed the pragmatic research philosophy, which enabled the combination of both qualitative and quantitative approaches to the research problem in an attempt to give a complete picture of the research issue. The deductive method of research was employed, in which already established theory and empirical research works involving labour rights, workplace safety, and worker welfare were employed in designing the research framework. The research design was the case study approach which assumed examination of two-three garment factories in the Gazipur District, which allowed conducting in-depth analysis of the practises of the workplace and labour rights in the actual organisational contexts. The information was gathered in several different ways, such as the surveys of the workers, semi-structured interviews, personal observations of the situation in the factories, and the analysis of the human resources policies and compliance documents. The application of all these kinds of sources of information enhanced the reliability and validity of the study because of the possibility to triangulate data. The survey questionnaire was useful in gathering quantitative related data about working hours, wages, safety at workplace as well as labour rights awareness whereas the interviews gave more detailed data on experience and perception of the workers. The observational strategies also enabled the researcher to analyse the physical premises and safety measures in the factories. The data obtained was evaluated through descriptive statistical methods and thematic analysis with the aim of establishing patterns, trends and critical issues that influence the workers. Tables, figures, and quotations of interview were offered to present the results, which made the interpretation of findings easier and compared them to the existing labour regulations and scholarly literature. In general, the research design is created in this chapter offered a decent and theoretically sound basis of exploring the facts of working conditions and labour rights in the garment industry in Bangladesh.

CHAPTER 4: FINDINGS AND ANALYSIS

4.1 Introduction

The chapter shows the empirical evidence as a result of field research that was conducted in the sampled ready-made garment factories located in Gazipur District, Bangladesh. It is analyzed through the data of the mixed-method research design discussed in Chapter 3 when structured questionnaires, face-to-face worker interviews, direct observation in the workplace, and factory practice analysis were employed to analyze the actual situation of the garment workers in the settings of industrial production. This chapter aims at looking at how the realities of factory employment dancing on the research objectives set out in Chapter 1, especially with regards to workplace safety, wage provisions, practice of overtime, awareness of labour rights, the state of occupational health, and practices that have enabled gender-based vulnerability in the factory employment structure. The chapter targets to offer both a quantitative and a qualitative interpretation of labour conditions in the form of the stories of the workers, beyond the documented compliance records. The chapter has been organised in a logical analytical order in case respondent characteristics are introduced beginning with thematic interpretation of each of the main separate features of labour conditions. The significance of demographic findings is that it forms social and economic background of the respondents and contributes to the explanation of why various categories of people feel the pressure at the workplace differently. Having outlined demographic features, the chapter proceeds with analysis of working hours, wage satisfaction, workplace safety, health conditions, knowledge of labour rights, complaint systems and gender-based experience. This structure provides the opportunity to understand every research objective individually and at the same time demonstrate how various issues of labour are still connected in practice. Indicatively, the patterns of overtime cannot be best comprehended minus factoring in on the wage adequacy and the knowledge of labour rights cannot be isolated as well as the worker confidence on the complaint systems. The synthesis developed with quantitative results of the survey is accompanied by the qualitative evidence received by analyzing the statement of the workers and observations at the field. The synthesis of this interpretation indicates the pragmatic methodological stance taken by the study when measurable pointers and lived experience are considered as equally significant in the understanding of industrial labour conditions. Pure statistical percentages are not the sole sufficient account of labour vulnerability and the same

cannot be linked with the explanations of workers as to why well-defined conditions persist. Similarly, the qualitative observations are fortified in cases where they are backed by survey patterns demonstrating the greater prevalence of certain experiences. This ambivalent interpretation makes the findings credible and renders the life in garment factories in Gazipur more realistic. The empirical findings have also been related in the chapter to the themes built in Chapter 2. The existing reference reported that since most of the industrial reforms made the factory compliance systems notable, several employees continue to work under a lot of pressure, low wages, stress in the workplace, poor collective voice, and unequal practical access to labour protection. The results of Gazipur exhibit the same continuity. Observable compliance has also been enhanced at various factories using safety gears, paper trails, and procedural controls but numerous structural pressures are deeply engrained in day-to-day production systems. Hence, the chapter does not only report field results but also starts demonstrating how formal labour regulation and real-world workplace persist in being different in the context of export-based garment manufacturing in Bangladesh.

4.2 Demographic Characteristics of Respondents

4.2.1 Gender Composition of Workers

The sample that was used in the survey comprised one hundred workers that were picked in sewing, cutting, finishing, and supervisory departments of the factories that had been selected. The gender distribution indicates the larger labour organization of the ready-made garment industry in Bangladesh, which sees the women workers taking the lead in producing the garments.

Table 9: Demographic Profile of Respondents

Variable	Category	Frequency	Percentage
Gender	Male	38	38%
Gender	Female	62	62%
Age	18–25 years	29	29%
Age	26–35 years	46	46%
Age	36–45 years	19	19%
Age	Above 45 years	6	6%
Department	Sewing	40	40%
Department	Cutting	20	20%
Department	Finishing	25	25%
Department	Supervisory	15	15%

Source: Author

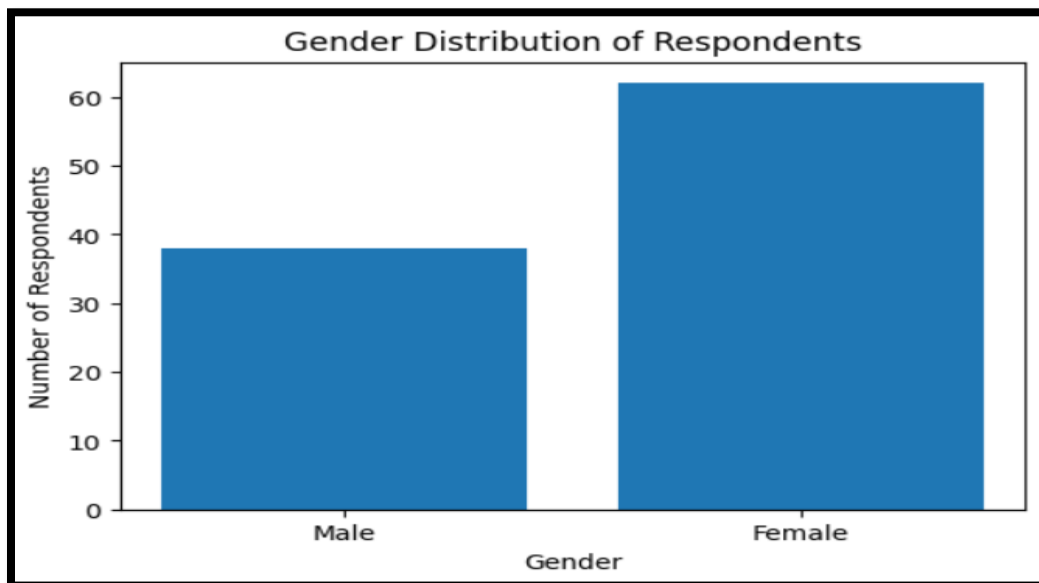
The data show (Table 9) that sixty two percent of the entire sample was made up of female respondents and thirty eight percent were made up of male respondents. The above finding is well congruent with the earlier literature which mentions that women form around sixty to sixty five percent of garment workers in Bangladesh. The involvement of females is still at the heart of the factory production since employers tend to identify female with accuracy, patience and reduced labour expenses. Age structure depicts that most of the respondents fall in the twenty-six to thirty-five age brackets and this shows that factories largely depend on economically productive adult worker at the prime productive age. The younger workers were prone to submit to the overtime needs without expressing themselves directly, unlike the older workers who were more concerned about fatigue and long-term health impacts.

4.2.2 Departmental Distribution

The internal labour structure that is general in the ready-made garment factories is reflected in the departmental distribution of respondents, where the sewing department possesses the highest percentage of production workers due to it being the most labour-intensive phase of garment manufacturing. In this study, a huge proportion of the respondents belonged to sewing lines which involve a lot of machine operation, division of work and close coordination with several operators as a means of ensuring that the line does not run sluggishly. The employees of this

division always mentioned increased pressure on production since line goals are reviewed during working hours and output timeouts cause delays on the next steps. Cutting section respondents comprised a less significant yet significant segment of the sample group and characterized more physical movement requirements as they need to lay lifted layers of fabric, use cutting machines, and move materials among workstations. The workers of the finishing sections also constituted a considerable amount and shared the experience that the constant muscle tension occurs due to the prolonged periods of thread trimming, ironing, folding, and packaging. The difference in labour experiences, which is departmental, can be used to justify the different labour experiences at various stages of factory production.

Figure 5: Gender Distribution of Respondents



Source: Author

The graph (Figure 5) shows gender distribution of respondents, with females (62) higher than males (38). This indicates female dominance in the sample, reflecting strong female participation in the garment workforce.

4.3 Working Hours and Overtime Conditions

4.3.1 Daily Working Duration

One of the most effective predictors of labour intensity during the research was the working hours. Respondents of the surveys have indicated that regular working hours are often worked under normal over time.

Table 10 shows most respondents work 11–12 hours (41%), followed by 9–10 hours (33%). Fewer work 8 hours (14%) or above 12 hours (12%), indicating extended working hours are common.

Table 10: Daily Working Hours of Respondents

WORKING HOURS	FREQUENCY	PERCENTAGE
8 HOURS	14	14%
9–10 HOURS	33	33%
11–12 HOURS	41	41%
ABOVE 12 HOURS	12	12%

Source: Author

The results indicate that fourteen percent of the workers indicated that they worked eight-hour shifts only. Forty-one percent stated that they were eleven to twelve hours in a day, and twelve percent worked actually more than twelve hours at peak production times. Such outcomes closely align with other publications which have found excessive overtime to be an endemic phenomenon in garment manufacturing systems in Bangladesh. Employees argued that overtime is particularly widespread in development to the shipment dates when foreign buyer arrangements add to the strain of production.

4.3.2 Overtime as Economic Necessity

Several respondents frequently mentioned that overtime is not a consequence of their employer pressuring them, but rather as an economic necessity as the monthly wages are not always enough to cover regular household costs. This is to say that overtime serves two purposes simultaneously; one is that overtime is the pressure on production within factories and on the other hand, it serves

as a basic survival tool of workers and their families because of low wages. According to the respondents, it will be very hard to make ends meet without overtime pay to meet rent, food, and transport payments, healthcare services, and other monthly bills. The female workers especially stressed the fact that income on overtime is significant in funding the education of the children, family remittances, and household upkeep. Some of the women told why whenever the issue of fatigue arises due to overtime, it is hard to decline to work more since the additional wage is a direct means of sustaining the family. The trend of this pattern validates previous labour literature that wage inadequacy endorses worker acceptance to prolonged work plans rendering overtime economically natural in garment employment schemes.

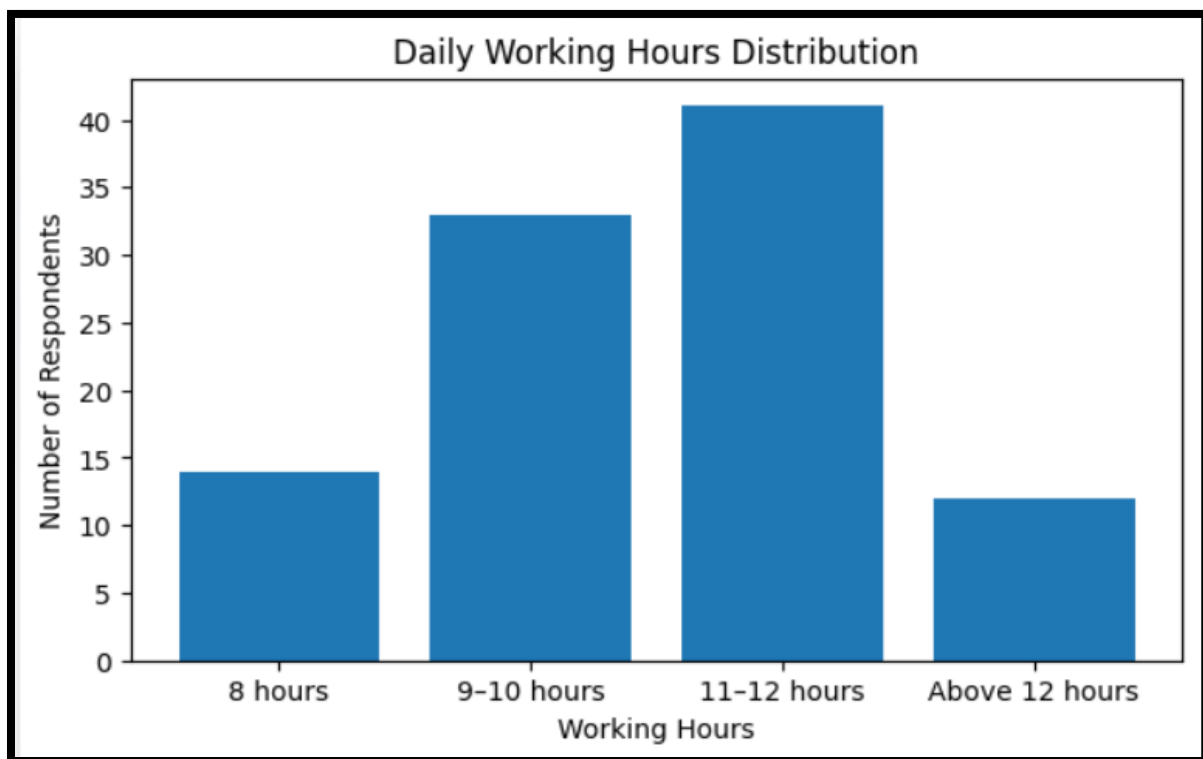


Figure 6: Daily Working Hours Distribution

Source: Author

This graph (Figure 6) shows that most respondents work 11–12 hours (41), followed by 9–10 hours (33). Fewer work 8 hours (14) or above 12 hours (12), indicating long working hours are common.

4.4 Wage Conditions and Income Satisfaction

4.4.1 Perception of Wage Adequacy

Wage satisfaction was investigated as wage perception has direct influence on the wellbeing of workers and labour stability.

Table 11 shows most respondents are dissatisfied (34%) with wages, followed by satisfied (24%) and neutral (18%). Fewer are highly dissatisfied (15%) or highly satisfied (9%), indicating low overall wage satisfaction.

Table 11: Wage Satisfaction Level

RESPONSE	FREQUENCY	PERCENTAGE
HIGHLY SATISFIED	9	9%
SATISFIED	24	24%
NEUTRAL	18	18%
DISSATISFIED	34	34%
HIGHLY DISSATISFIED	15	15%

Source: Author

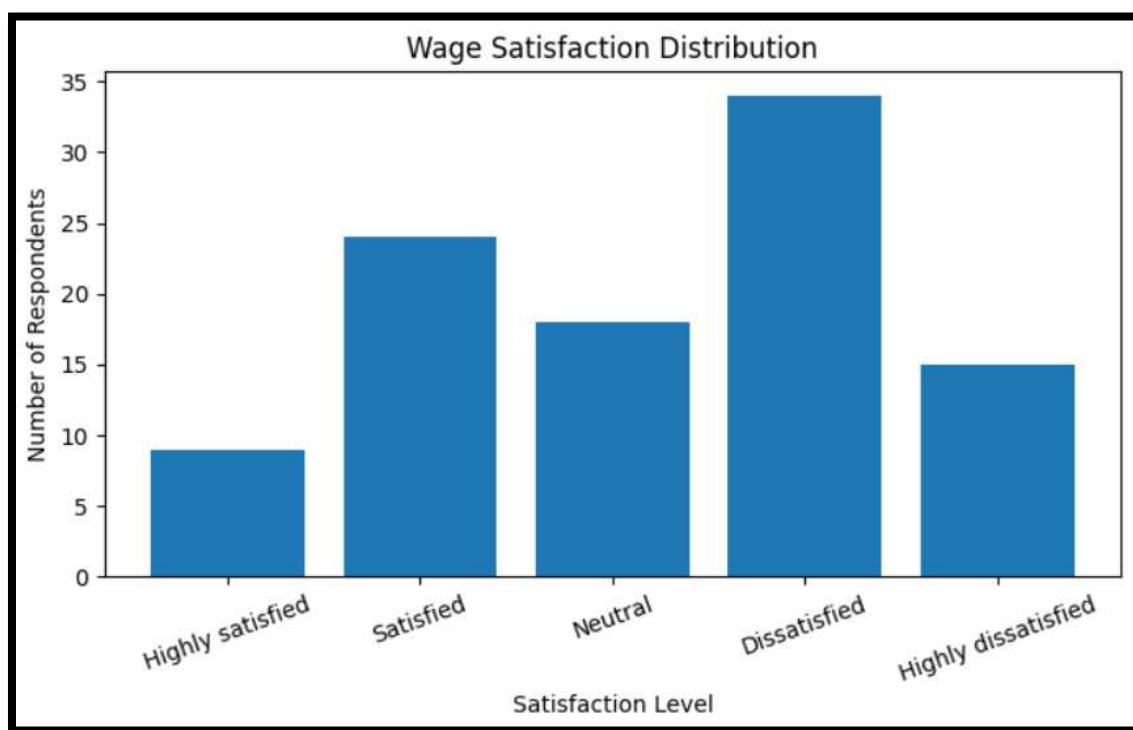
Most employees reported discontentment with pay. Thirty four percent were dissatisfied and the per cent of high dissatisfaction was fifteen percent. The most persuasive reason put forward by the respondents was wages fall short of livelihood in Gazipur particularly rents, transport, food prices and family needs. Employees kept saying that monthly salary is exhausted prior to the month end. These findings back up the earlier literature that legal wage rates tend to be lower than real-life wage requirements in the industrial districts.

4.4.2 Wage and Productivity Relationship

Most employees pointed that the low pay worsens the psychological strain since the level of production gets higher but the salary rate does not go up in a corresponding manner. Respondents elaborated that the daily output targets are carefully checked and employees are supposed to be fast and accurate even when monthly earnings are low compared to living expenses. It sets a scenario where employees are pressured by not only necessities of labour physically but also by the opinion that higher production does not necessarily result in significant change in finances.

Some of the respondents reported that attendance bonuses, overtime pay, and occasional incentive earnings are useful in raising the total monthly earnings, though they are not permanently fixed as they are based on the continued attendance rates, productions plans and the quantity of orders received by the factory. The employees as a result tend to consider their salary as not completely predictable. This fluctuating correlation between work and compensation is one of the factors leading to frustration and mental strains, especially when production is at peak levels and many employees see no growth on the monetary scale.

Figure 7: Wage Satisfaction Distribution



Source: Author

The graph (Figure 7) shows that most respondents are dissatisfied (34) with wages, followed by satisfied (24) and neutral (18). Fewer are highly dissatisfied (15) or highly satisfied (9), indicating overall low wage satisfaction.

4.5 Workplace Safety and Physical Conditions

4.5.1 Safety Infrastructure

The apparent safety situations in the garment factories inspected in the survey are much better than what was found in the older factory settings presented in previous labour investigation. Majority of the respondents affirmed that fire extinguishing systems, emergency laying out signs, alarm systems and evacuation routes are now eminent on factory floors. These obvious progressions are the result of making the garment industry in Bangladesh more compliance-oriented, which began as significant industrial safety reforms. Yet, another significant contrast that workers also made was visible compliance and practical confidence in real emergency situations. Most of the respondents even though safety devices are present on the ground were not certain that all the workers would be able to act effectively in the event of an actual emergency. Sixty seven percent of the surveyed employees affirmed that fire extinguishers were well visible in places of work, but fewer employees affirmed of complete confidence of evacuation in case of production work under crowded condition. Some employees indicated that the presence of equipment is not an effective way of eliminating fear since it is hard to move through crowded production areas fast during emergencies. These results affirm the previous findings that indicate that compliance is often procedural as opposed to being operational in actual practice.

4.5.2 Emergency Preparedness

Fire drills are also reported to be conducted by the workers in the factories that are under the survey, although a large number of respondents did not feel that such drills are often enough to develop a high level of confidence in behaving during emergencies. Some employees gave their observations that though evacuation guidelines are issued effectively verbally by the employers or posted on notice boards, actual physical drills are minimal. This implies that employees have standard emergency information but still may feel of confusion whenever a real evacuation scenario hits with crowded production floors where movement should be done swiftly. According to some of the respondents, some new workers are usually given short verbal training without undergoing an experience in repetitive practical trainings. Some of them attributed it to the fact that at times fire drills are held during compliance checks as opposed to regular intervals throughout the year. This generates half-hearted confidence and not complete readiness.

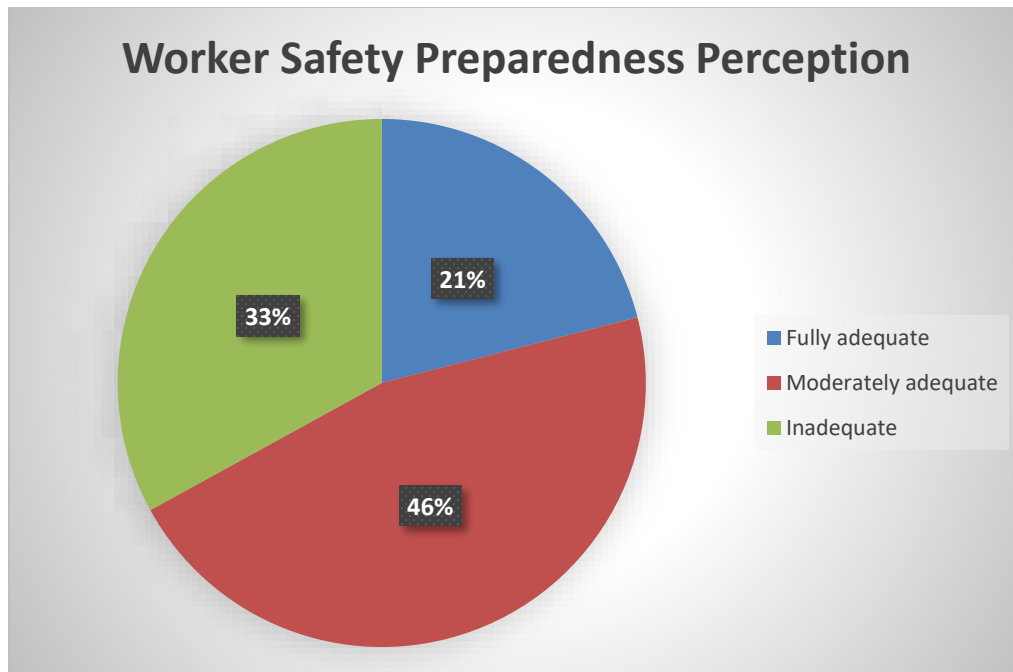


Figure 8: Worker Safety Preparedness Perception

Source: Author

The chart (Figure 8) shows workers' safety preparedness perceptions: 46% consider conditions moderately adequate, 33% inadequate, and only 21% fully adequate, indicating significant concern and room for improvement in workplace safety measures.

4.6 Health and Hygiene Conditions

4.6.1 Physical Health Effects

Employees constantly complained of physical discomfort about manual repetitive work in the industry, which suggests that health burden is still a significant issue of daily concerns in garment factory work. Lower back pain, eye strain, neck stiffness, leg pain, shoulder pain, and general physical fatigue upon work shifts of long duration were the most illustrative complaints that respondents reported. Workers in the sewing section especially cited that constant sitting with in turn positions when working with machines to be the cause of lower back pain, and muscular rigidity, especially when the overtime hours are past the regular working hours. Due to the need to maintain visual attention on stitching lines, eye strain and headaches were also agreed on by many workers at the end of the day. At the finishing part, the respondents explained that long working hours were the key factors that had contributed to fatigue in legs and foot pains, especially

during the packaging and quality inspection processes. This development suggests that monotony of movement and worst of all the prolonged body position also forms ergonomic stress in departments. The findings are very similar to other past studies that report ergonomic weakness as an undetected yet chronic occupational health challenge in garment factories.

4.6.2 Medical Support and Sanitation

The majority of the respondents noted that they had first aid units within the factories that were surveyed, and the employees were generally aware of the fact that they have simple medical provisions as a form of administration as part of the official compliance regulations. Nevertheless, according to most workers, it still lacks practical medical assistance, especially in the busy production phase, when it becomes more challenging to obtain help. Some of the respondents indicated that there are first aid boxes and roomy medical rooms but the treatment is normally limited and only addresses minor injuries like cuts, headaches, or temporary tiredness. When the production targets are high, the female respondents in particular have pointed out that chances to get short rest when they are experiencing physical discomfort is usually insufficient. According to some women, asking to be allowed to take a rest during the busy periods is simply an inviting trait and their supervisors would insist on working even when they feel uncomfortable. Esposito and sanitation were usually reported to be good and toilets and washing facilities were provided, but the respondents observed that cleanliness is dependent on the size of the factory floors, the number of workers in that area, and the frequency of cleaning. High workforce in most cases puts pressure on the sanitation facilities during the working peak hours.

4.7 Labor Rights Awareness

4.7.1 Awareness of Legal Rights

One of the key conclusions of this paper is that most garment workers do not know about their formal labour rights even though there are national labour laws and factory compliance regulations. The majority of the respondents knew that overtime employment is a recognised condition, but most of them could not describe what the legal overtime rate is and how overtime allowances are calculated in connection with the labour law. Information about the annual leaves, sick leaves, maternity and official working time constraints was also lacking in a significant section of employees. Some of the respondents mentioned that they act in line with the factory instructions

without necessarily knowing whether all the processes are within the stipulations of the law or not. This poor awareness of formal grievance procedures and written complaint systems was particularly and significantly low since many workers had never been explained in depth about how such systems work in fact. This observation concurs with previous studies in the field of labour that suggest that the presence of the labour law does not necessarily result into empowerment of labour unless the legal information becomes both available and comprehensible by the workers working in the day-to-day factory business.

4.7.2 Complaint Mechanisms

Employee reports indicated that grievances within the factories are normally delineated orally via the instant line managers than by official written communications. Minor problems like machine hassle, attendance problems, or production strain are reported directly to supervisors in most cases since to the workers this is a faster and less risky way of reporting than an official report. Nonetheless, there was very little formal written complaint regime even when complaint boxes or specific procedures were adopted within the premises of the factory. A number of the respondents articulated those employees will fear any adverse responses made against them in case complaints are written down, especially when the matter is related to management behaviour, overtime pressures, or dissatisfaction on salary. Such fear lowers the levels of trust in official grievance systems and promotes informal communication instead. Discussion on union was also low among the respondents with a high number of workers stating that they did not have active interaction with organised labour representation within their factories. These results pose an indication that the complaint systems are more evident in legal compliance structure compared to informal worker confidence, which limits the efficiency of labor protection processes.

4.8 Gender and Workplace Vulnerability

4.8.1 Female Worker Experience

Women respondents outlined a significantly greater degree of emotional and economic vulnerability in contrast with male employees, in large part thanks to the fact that the profit gained in their factories is linked directly to family survival and house stability. Most women those interviewed confirmed that monthly income is not spent solely at improving personal need but rather education of children, elderly parents, rent, food and in some instances unemployed spouses

or relatives. This brings about this situation where employment is extremely significant beyond personal economic self-sufficiency. Some of the respondents said that they can hardly imagine quitting the job when it is physically demanding or emotionally taxing since other family obligations require one to continue earning. Female employees also complained more about apprehensions about attendance, punctuality, and supervisor assessment since any amount of wage deduction has an immediate implication on household budget. Mostly, women were worried that a raised complaint might ruin their relationship with supervisors along the line or less opportunities to work overtime in future. This economic dependence consequently diminishes their readiness regarding any form of confronting authority even in the event of dissatisfaction. The results are a solid affirmation of the fact that female labour engagement in the garment industry is still actually associated with the larger household economic dependency, as the women in question tend to be more susceptible to work pressure and cannot freely create labour terms and conditions in the factory setting.

4.8.2 Gendered Pressure

Some female employees complained that during high production milestones, the pressure at the workplace is very high especially when export dates and the need to generate lines of products and extended overtime. These periods the women stated that the supervisors are very attentive to production speed and attendance since any delay in one section will impact the entire production line. Women responding stated that female pressure is more challenging when it is compounded with domestic issues as most of them have to work at home and even when they are away. Other concerns such as maternity issues were raised with trepidation by some of the respondents and pertaining to the fear of job loss due to leave, promotions, or even a bad attitude by the supervisors once the employee comes back to work. Though lawful maternity benefits are officially in place, uncertainty was also evident among some workers on the willingness of factory environments to accommodate them during pregnancy or after they give birth. Some of the respondents enlightened me that women do not want to talk about the pregnancy at an early age due to the fear of not being considered productive. These results are well in line with past gender vulnerability literature in the Bangladesh ready-made garment industry where women are still at the center of industrial activities and are still subject to unequal social and occupational aspects burdening them of

reproductive aspects needing attention, economic reliance, and low bargaining power amid hierarchal factory systems.

4.9 Departmental Comparison

4.9.1 Sewing Section

The sewing segment between the garment factories surveyed showed to be the most production intense segment due to the fact that the productivity of manufacturers using this line is tracked across the entire working day. The sewing workers are directly involved in the main part of the garment manufacturing, the core assembly stage when each worker has an allocated machine activity which he or she is required to finish within the rigid hourly production standards. According to respondents of this section, the monitoring of output figures, machine pace and line balance are also carried out by the supervisor on a regular basis, and this leads to a continuous psychological stress at the work place. Minor disruptions due to thread breakage, machine tune up, or damaged fabrics can influence the target achievement and create employee stress. Physical discomfort was also noticed by many sewing operators due to long sitting hours, repetitive motion of the hands, and constant visual undivided attention on the correctness of the stitching. Since sewing work directly affects the pace of the production line as a whole, employees in this department face more pressure than most of others, especially during export shipment dates when schedules in which buyers receive their due products are tightened.

4.9.2 Cutting Section

Workers who work in the cutting department said they experienced another form of labour intensity in comparison with the sewing operators since their job involves more physical motion and handling of bundles of fabric. Tasks to be cut include laying fabric sheets, laying markers, cutting machine, and relaying ready material to the sewing lines. The respondents identified that, such activities require constant movement of the upper body, lifting frequently as well as stretching of the arm, and in this case, the shoulder strains and arm muscles become exhausted at the end of the workday. Contrary to sewing operators who spend substantial amounts of time seated, cutting section workers routinely move around the production floor and remain fast and accurate. The quality of the cutting is highly rated as any error will surely impact on the subsequent stages of production, creating extra strain at the time of high production demands. Some of the respondents

mentioned that they experience pain in their shoulders and pain in their wrists particularly when the production levels go up. These results suggest that total act of work despite being less visually monotonous than sewing imposes severe physical strain due to the use of manual power and prolonged movement.

4.9.3 Finishing Section

Respondents indicated the finishing section as physically strenuous since employees spend a significant amount of time standing as they repeat tasks related to the preparation of garments to be shipped. Quality finishing can be done in form of thread trimming, ironing, folding, quality checking, tagging and packing and all these need to be done fast so that the schedule of shipment will not be missed. Employees stated that extended standing usually leads to discomfort in their legs, foot pains, and back pains particularly on long working hours of overtime. Due to the fact that finishing work is done towards the almost the end of the production process, there is usually a rapid increase in pressure on to the completion of work as delivery time nears. These repetitive motions of hands were also found to cause fatigue at the wrists over time as reported by respondents when folding and packaging. Contrary to sewing or cutting, where machine work is associated with the work accomplished, finishing calls the maintenance of a body posture and hand repetitive work on the finished garments. Lots of employees reported that the part is especially hectic when the short-complete garments cannot be delivered in time by the previous sections, which forces the finishing workers to speed up their work to comply with exportation timelines and ensure the continuation of shipments.

4.9.4 Supervisory Level

The respondents at the supervisory level said that they were more conscious of the labour regulations and the factory compliance procedures as their tasks demand continuous communication with the management instructions, the attendance systems, and the production monitoring. Supervisors tend to have a better appreciation of formal guidelines of working hours, recording overtime, process of taking leave and safety measures as compared to manufacturing personnel. Nevertheless, they also noted that the responsibility to be more accountable in production since they are personally in charge of making sure that targets are met daily. Supervisors said that when production delays are involved, they frequently are pressured by the higher management especially when the buyer orders are urgent. This places them in a tough

situation where they have to balance on task or discipline of the workers as well as promote productivity and address compliance mandates. A number of supervisors admitted that they are aware of the complaints workers make about fatigue and salary issues but they cannot influence the decisions to modify production. Their status thus takes the form of a middle ground between the management and labour regarding, there being regulation awareness but operational pressure still being high as a result of the target-driven industrial control systems.

4.10 Overall Analytical Interpretation

4.10.1 Compliance Improvement and Practical Workplace Reality

The general findings of the analysis suggest that significant compliance measures have been established within the targeted garment facilities especially in the visible on areas like fire safety gear, emergency facilities, time keeping, company documents, and fundamental quality of control. These developments are indicative of the post-reform initiative by the Bangladesh ready-made garment industry to enhance international acceptability as well as address labour issues raised internationally. Nonetheless, the materials gathered among employees show that the claimed enhancements cannot be full-fledged when one studies them through the prism of the daily labour experience. Despite the increased visibility of physical compliance indicators within factory premises, in the daily employment practice, many workers still report being operationally pressured related to production goals, extended working hours, and no influence in making decisions linked to their everyday jobs. This indicates formal compliance does not necessarily result in the enhancement of better labour wellbeing as most structural pressures still span below the observable regulatory frameworks.

4.10.2 Economic Pressure and Labour Dependency

The results highly affirm that increasing overtime dependency is still among the overwhelming significant mechanisms by which production pressure is ensured within factories. Employees are ready to work longer in their jobs since they need overtime pay to supplement their monthly salaries which are not always adequate. Practically, the the overtime has turned into a survival tactic in terms of finances instead of optional labour practice. This shows that the relationship between wage insufficiency and labour dependency is still in a direct relation. Employees often justified that basic pay by itself will not be enough to subsidize food, housing and transport,

medical expenses and family. Consequently, employees still work on challenging shifts when they are extremely fatigued. The trend directly underlines the larger thesis established in Chapter 2 that labour vulnerability cannot be addressed just by conformity when economic dependency is still institutionally inbuilt in an industrial employment system.

4.10.3 Limited Worker Voice and Acceptance of Difficult Conditions

The other significant analytical finding cannot be ignored that dissatisfaction does not always result in open resistance and protest. Most employees have raised the issue of salaries, medical stress and administration pressure, but official grievances are few. This is mostly due to the fact that there are only fewer job options and no guarantee of job security. Employees will then inevitably accept the hard conditions not because they believe they are good, but because they are afraid of losing their jobs which presents a bigger economic challenge. This trend was observed more among the female workers since factory income is often more stable and the financial responsibilities of the household often make them more reliant on the factory income. This means that limited worker voice is a significant aspect of labour reality which demonstrates that formal labour rights are pragmatically present on policy than on practical bargaining power in factory settings.

4.11 Chapter Summary

The chapter was an analytical study of the empirical research that was carried out on garment workers who were employed at the selected ready-made garment factories in Gazipur District in Bangladesh. The survey responses, field observations, and worker interviews outlined in the research methodology were analyzed to develop work on assessing the real working conditions experienced by the employees working in the industrial production system. The results show that despite some apparent gains that are implemented in a few factories and even more so when speaking about safety gear, emergency signage, and formal compliance plans, there exist immense challenges that pose challenges to the daily lives of employees. These issues demonstrate a significant disparity between formally reported labour compliance and the real world of the workplace.

The findings indicate that working hours are still one of the most significant issues of employees. Many of the respondents stated that they are in overtime daily work schedules that go beyond the

normal working day, with them playing a day-to-day part in factory work, instead of a one or two-day necessity. In most situations, overtime was being tolerated not only due to production pressure but also because workers require extra income to support their family needs. This suggests that the low wage rates still enforce the ideology of long working hours, and economic survival is tightly associated with labour intensity. The same observation has been established in previous researches on the Bangladesh garment industry where wage inadequacy and overtime reliance are still organically related to the export production systems.

The results of the wage satisfaction also prove that a significant portion of the workforce is not satisfied with the level of income. Despite formal wage payments that are being continued based on factory schedules, workers gave consistent responses that monthly wages are not very sufficient when compared to the increases in living costs such as food, housing, transport and family obligations. This economic strain is a direct cause of tension among workers and the feasibility of works legislative wages. Moreover, the awareness of labour rights amongst the majority of the respondents is still low. Though employees are familiar with general regulations of attendance and overtime procedures, the specific information about their legal rights, workplace grievance policies, entitlement to leave, and official channels of filing complaints is a weak part and makes the employees less effective in their efforts to question any unjust treatment.

The health-related reports state that repetitive industrial processes still create physical pain especially back pain, eye pain, neck pain, and physical exhaustion. The female employees complained that they were more vulnerable since in most cases they are discovered to be putting work in the factories and at the same time taking care of the family, which adds more emotional and physical stress to the employees. Despite the increased visual level of compliance with safety, the majority of the workers remarked as unsure about practical emergency preparedness. In general, the chapter aims to confirm that labour rights are more evident in institutional forms of formal organization, than in workplace practice. These results are the empirical basis of Chapter 5, which will further develop the discussion of Chapter 5 by linking the results with the labour governance theory, compliance arguments, and issues of industrial policy.

CHAPTER 5: DISCUSSION

5.1 Introduction

Through critically interpreting the empirical results of Chapter 4, this chapter compares these results to the objectives of the research, research questions, and the proven literature. The discussion combines both the quantitative survey findings with the qualitative information in the form of workers interview and observation and hence complies with the practical mixed-method approach, which has been used in the study. It is not merely to narrate the findings but to infer why this kind of patterns occurs and how it is a manifestation of larger structural, economic and social dynamics of the Ready-Made Garment (RMG) industry in Bangladesh.

Moreover, the chapter attempts to fill the research gap between theory and practice through bridging between field-level observations and the scholarly discussions on labor rights, industrial relations and governance of global supply chains. The Gazipur results are not considered in form of isolated results but in the form of a large system which is developed through economic globalizations, labor market, and limitations imposed by institutions. In so doing, the discussion is a closer insight into the functioning of formal policies and compliance mechanisms in the real world and how they are lived by the workers in their everyday lives.

This discussion will be organized around critical thematic areas, such as the working hours, wage conditions, occupational safety, health and hygiene, the understanding of labor rights, and gender-based vulnerabilities. Each part aims at comparing field discoveries in Gazipur with the prior academic researches and policy frameworks to find out the similarities, inconsistencies and rediscoveries. Moreover, the chapter emphasizes the interrelatedness of the mentioned problems as low wages become the cause of excessive overtime, or lack of awareness of labor rights results in the inability to require safer working conditions.

This chapter, by integrating both empirical and theoretical viewpoints, not only confirms the already existing literature, but also adds new aspects, in the context of Gazipur. Finally, it presents a critical and detailed explanation of the reality of garment workers and preconditions knowledgeable conclusions and viable policies formulation in the following chapter.

5.2 Working Hours and Labor Intensity

Long working hours and excessive overtime in this case is one of the most important findings of this study. The survey findings suggest that most of the workers usually work about 10-12 hours daily and a significant number of them work more than 12 hours during the period of peak production. This observation is highly consistent with earlier studies where Uz-Zaman and Khan (2021) emphasize that overtime is an element of the structure of the RMG industry and not a one-time practice.

It can be seen in the discussion that overtime is not only forced upon by the factory management, but also telemed that workers believe that overtime is an economic necessity. This two-sidedness of overtime, which is both coerced and self-imposed, is an indication of an underlying structural problem in the labor market. Employees rely on overtime wages to take care of fundamental living costs implying that minimum pay is not adequate. This confirms the claim made by Haolader and Khan (2022) that the labor behaviour in the developing economies is often motivated by the survival strategies in the economy. Here, overtime is accepted as a customary work culture instead of being viewed as a stressor and weight.

Furthermore, the acceptance of long working hours has serious consequences to physical and psychological health of workers. Excessive working hours are seen to lead to fatigue, stress, and low productivity in the long run. Employees get little time to rest, interact with their family and their personal development, which impacts negatively on their quality of life. Repeated exposure to such stressful work arrangements may also cause an increase in workplace accidents since employees are more likely to commit errors and are slower to respond.

In addition, the pressures in terms of global supply chains are of key importance in influencing working hours. According to Rahman et al. (2025), international customers expect strict deadlines and cost requirements, which render themselves in the deepening of work challenges on the shop floor. This dynamic is supported by the results of Gazipur where workers said that there was a rising number of overtime when there was a shipment deadline. In their bid to stay relevant in the global market, the factories tend to make timely delivery a priority at the expense of the welfare of the workers thus shifting the burden of production directly to the employees.

Moreover, lax enforcement of regulations enables the practices to continue. Even though there are labor laws that specify the extent to which working hours should be, there are no effective monitoring mechanisms making the factories to take advantage of such laws as they can move beyond the legal limits and work beyond them without much being done to them. As a consequence of economic need and the fear of unemployment the workers seldom protest against these infractions.

Therefore, working excess hours within the RMG sector cannot just be perceived as a labor management problem but needs to be interpreted in the context of global capitalism, low wages, and pressure on production. The solution to this problem is a set of actions in which the government can regulate the situation, international buyers can provide fair wages, and can apply responsible sourcing habits.

5.3 Wage Conditions and Economic Vulnerability

These results show that dissatisfaction with wages is widespread with almost half of the people surveyed being dissatisfied or of high dissatisfaction. This is in close relation to the literature, especially the article by Uz-Zaman and Khan (2021), that states that minimum wage laws in Bangladesh are usually not associated with living wage. As demonstrated in the discussion, wage inadequacy is not an exclusively economic issue but a multidimensional problem that relates to the well-being and mental health of workers, as well as their productivity. Workers complain that the wages they earn are not enough to meet some basic needs like house, foods, health and education of their children. This result correlates with Shammi et al. (2024), who accentuate that low income of garment workers adversely affects family nutrition and child welfare.

In addition to basic needs, wage insufficiency has implications on the long-term financial security and social mobility of workers. There are numerous employees who cannot save their money or invest in their skills development and they have fewer chances to get professionally advanced. This establishes a chain of dependence as employees get stuck in low wages that they receive without much prospects of improving. Finance is another cause of anxiety and fatigue, which may impair attention and possibility of accidents or errors at the workplace.

The other important problem that has been recognized is the poor correlation between productivity and compensation. Employees complained that higher production goals do not go proportional to

higher wages. This compounds a feeling of injustice and demotivation to work, in line with the results of Aktar (2021) who mentioned that poor dissatisfaction with compensation systems is a factor to grievances at work. The lack of fair reward to workers based on their efforts may result into disengagement and reduced overall productivity and eventually organizations performance.

Also the instability of wages that is caused by reliance on overtime and incentives results in financial instability. The workers are not able to foresee their monthly earnings, which adds to the level of stress and financial insecurity. Such uncertainty complicates planning of household spending or managing emergencies by the workers. Thus, the research confirms the thesis that the wage regimes within the RMG industry are not structurally appropriate and that they need to be overhauled once again, with the implementation of living wages, transparent compensation systems, and additional control.

5.4 Workplace Safety and Compliance Reality

It can be argued that due to the findings of the study, the state of safety in the workplace has to be better than in the previous state, especially in regards to the obvious safety resources, i.e. fire extinguishers, emergency exits, alarm system, etc. It can be considered as an effect of post-disaster reforms and international compliance programs. But, the discussion exposes an imperative disjuncture between formal adherence and preparedness in the field. Workers were not so convinced that they could react aptly in the case of emergencies. The discovery is consistent with Miah et al. (2023), who maintain that compliance within the textile sector in Bangladesh is mostly concerned with the observable signs but not determined by its functionality.

In a more precise look, it can be seen that the implementation of safety measures is usually made to meet the needs of external auditing instead of developing a safety culture within the company. Although there are equipment and signage, it is not always the case that workers are engaging in meaningful training or participatory safety practices. This diminishes their effectiveness in responding with confidence in the actual crisis situations. The number and quality of fire drills are also low which further undermines preparedness to emergencies. Employees complained that exercises are uncommon and in other cases are performed because it is mandatory, and not because it is considered a normal safety measure. Consequently, employees might be familiar with

emergency exit in theory, but have a deficiency of practical experience when it comes to escaping the building during emergency situations.

Also, the high traffic on factory floors and production stress diminish the efficiency of the safety measures. Empty space and the panic effect and physical barriers can prove to be a problem even in cases where equipment has been provided. Scheduling high production levels usually dishearten workers to consider safety measures since deadlines have overridden the importance of safety measures. This points out that safety is both a technical and an organizational, and behavioral problem that is dependent on management priorities and workplace culture.

Moreover, there is no effective worker involvement in safety planning, which reduces the effectiveness of available measures. Safety systems are kept top-down and less responsive to the real conditions when the workers are not proactively engaged in risks identification and the creation of solutions. The study, therefore, substantiates that though compliance has improved, it is still more symbolic than functional, which substantiates broader possess of CSR and audit based systems within global supply chains.

5.5 Health and Hygiene Conditions

The observations indicate that occupation health problems are common in the garment workers especially musculoskeletal pain, fatigue and eye strain. These issues can be directly attributed to the working hours, monotony, and poor ergonomic conditions.

This aligns with the findings of Das et al. (2022) who also discovered that the health risks among garment workers in Bangladesh are severe because of conditions at the workplaces. As pointed out in the discussion, compliance frameworks seldom focus on ergonomics concerns; they are more concerned with structural safety and health risks in everyday life.

Factories also have medical facilities which are limited in provision. Employees have complained that medical attention is normally rudimentary and not enough in case of serious health issues. This goes hand in hand with Ayub et al. (2026) highlighting the need to have better access to health services via workplace programs like Model Enterprise Clinics.

Sanitation generally was reported as being satisfactory though overcrowding has an influence on sanitation and access. This implies that better hygiene infrastructure has to be accompanied with better management practices to make it an effective one.

Comprehensively, the results prove that health risks in the RMG sector are not incidental, but inherent in structures of production systems.

5.6 Labor Rights Awareness and Worker Voice

Among the most significant implications of this research is the overall lack of understanding of the labor rights among the workers. The awareness of what is legally their right in terms of wages, working hours and grievance procedures was unknown to many respondents. This ignorance goes a long way undermining the capacity by workers to assert their rights. Workers may also fear loss of their jobs which prevents them to complain even when they know that it will occur. This result greatly confirms Nahar (2024), who points out that workplace problems are underreported in fear of unwanted to be perceived as weaker and powerless.

The further understanding is that this lack of awareness is not a mere coincidence but it is structurally and institutionally influenced. A great number of employees are poorly educated, and it also limits their means of accessing the information regarding labor legislation and official practices. Also, more likely the factories lack proper training or orientation program about the rights of workers, which contributes to this knowledge gap. This leads to employees continuing to rely on personal conversation and colleagues know-how, which can be partial or incorrect.

There are grievance-handling mechanisms available but are typically viewed as ineffective, or are discriminatory against the management. There was no trust in these systems as workers showed very low confidence. This is consistent with Aktar (2021), who discovered that poor grievance policies lower worker satisfaction and commitment to an organization. At times, employees perceive that lodging grievances could result in subtle retaliations that could affect their opportunities to work overtime, get unfavorable job descriptions, or even be dismissed, thus making them shun official routes.

Minimal involvement of trade unions was also observed. Employees mentioned being afraid of intimidation, which is indicative of more systemic preventing health collective action within the

RMG industry. This pit of the lack of solid worker representation restricts the possibility of bargaining towards better terms and conditions and supports the dominance of the employer in decision making.

Accordingly, the paper can assert that the enforcement of labor rights can be restricted not only by the ineffective regulation but also by the imbalance of power and the susceptibility of workers. To do away with this problem, extra law frameworks are not sufficient, it has to be coupled with awareness, independent complaint procedures, and safeguard strategies that will enable employees to exercise their rights without intimidation.

5.7 Gender Dimension and Worker Vulnerability

One of the major themes of this paper is the gender aspect because women represent the largest segment of the labor force. The results showcase empowerment as well as vulnerability in terms of female garment workers. On the one hand, women become financially independent and socially mobile with the help of employment. Women on the other hand have innumerable challenges such as job insecurity, harassment and work and house responsibilities. This paradox can be regarded as this duality, which is also mentioned by Nazneen and Hossain (2024), proposing the complicated connection between employment and job satisfaction in a female worker.

Besides economic engagement, the research demonstrates that a large proportion of women have a form of confined empowerment in which monetary autonomy does not always result into an enhanced decision-making authority and enhanced quality of life. The culture and the nature of patriarchy tend to restrict the level to which women might use their income to the fullest. The health/condition of women, although women do contribute largely to household income, they may still be less able to influence financial decisions, which boosts the status quo in gender hierarchies.

Other vulnerabilities described in the study are based on gender, including less access to maternity benefits and childcare. These problems influence the women in their capacity of maintaining employment, which confirms the results of Shammi et al. (2024) concerning the effectiveness of work settings on family welfare. In most instances, lack of proper childcare options causes women to use informal options, which might be perilous or untrustworthy. This adds more stress and may cause employment breaks, which undermines even more employment security.

Moreover, the problem of unreported harassment is not negligible. Women are afraid of social stigma, victim-blaming, and losing their jobs, which contributes to structural inequality. The lack of power among the workers with supervisors encourages complaints even more and provides an opportunity to neglect the abusive practice and do not want to be challenged.

Therefore, although the RMG sector has facilitated females to enter into the economic arena, still, the sector reproduces gender-based inequalities. To counter these issues, there is need to come up with gender conscious policies, enhanced effects of labor rights and safe and conducive workplace conditions so that women can be able to work with dignity and safety.

5.8 Environmental and Sustainability Dimensions

The main issue of this research is the labor conditions, but environmental concerns are indirectly related to the well-being of workers. Research like Masum et al. (2025) emphasize the adverse effect of textile effluents on water resources, which can impact its workers and the communities. Likewise, Sorker et al. (2023) highlight the environmental impact of the industrial growth on areas such as Gazipur in a wider scale. The discussion indicates that there is a mutual existence between environmental sustainability and labor rights, whereby inadequate environmental practices may worsen the health risks.

In a lot of industrial areas, poor sewage wastes, chemical effluents and air pollution provide a poor working and living environment to the garment workers. When workers live in the neighborhood around factory locations they tend to get exposed to contaminated sources of water and polluted air that may cause them to contract respiratory diseases, skin ailments and health complication in the long term. These hazards to the environment are not only in the factory floor but also in the families of the workers and strain the already scarce healthcare facilities. Hence, the ecological balance is not only compromised by environmental degradation, but also the social and economic vulnerability of workers increases significantly.

A shift towards green practices, as argued by Rahman et al. (2025), has its opportunities and challenges. On the one hand, environmentally friendly technologies of production and waste treatment, energy-efficient operations can play an important role in minimizing the environmental impact and enhancing the health status of the population of the working environment. Conversely, such practices can be expensive in terms of finance, and small factories might not afford to

implement these changes. This might impose disparities in the industry with only large or export-oriented factories implementing sustainable actions and leaving small units behind.

In addition, it must be ensured that the transitions towards sustainability are non-discriminatory and people-focused. Environmental compliance is not the only aspect of green transformation but should be supplemented with working conditions, health protection, and social welfare. In the absence of such integration, sustainability initiatives may serve as just another instance of embodiment of compliance instead of being a real avenue towards fair and responsible industrial growth.

5.9 Synthesis of Key Findings

The discussion has pinpointed some of the main points: there is an improvement of compliance concerning working conditions but this does not translate to reality; wage inadequacy is one of the focal points of propelling overtime, and economic vulnerability; safety provision is found to be visible even though it is not complete rather than pointless; health hazard is entrenched to production; labor rights consciousness and implementation are too weak; and gender disparities exist despite the

All these findings show that the development witnessed in the RMG sector is more of a procedural process, than a transformational process. Although factories have implemented compliance systems to achieve both national laws and international buyer standards, they do not usually reflect in the overall changes in the daily lives of workers. The endurance of the male-dominated long working hours and use of overtime is reflective of not having any wage mode that can support the lovely living standards thus making workers to sell their health and personal time to survive.

Additionally, the mismatch between apparent safety infrastructure and real preparedness is one of the most striking shortcomings in implementation. Safety has been learned to be a check list requirement instead of an organizational culture which tends to undermine its effectiveness when in actual emergencies. Equally, occupational health problems like fatigue and musculoskeletal pains, and stress reveal that production mechanisms are devised with an overwhelming concern on output at the expense of the workers.

The weak understanding and implementation of labor rights also contribute to the worker vulnerability. Workers lack sufficient understanding or faith to enforce their rights which keeps on them a dependence on management practices that do not necessarily take their welfare first. This power imbalance is most noticeable among the female workers who still have to contend with further issues of job insecurity, societal expectation and discrimination at the workplace.

By and large, these observations evidenced the fact that the RMG industry functions in a superbly crunchy system that is being influenced by economic compulsions, global supply chains, and societal forces. These issues are not only to solve through regulatory fixes but through the structural adjustments that affirm the workers dignity, fair pay, and sustainable manufacturing.

CHAPTER 6: CONCLUSION AND RECOMMENDATIONS

6.1 Conclusion

In the present research, the objectives were to evaluate the working conditions and labor rights in the Ready-Made Garment industry in Bangladesh, and in particular the Gazipur District. The results indicate a nuanced fact that is both encouraging and data-filled. Although there have been opportunities to enhance compliance mechanisms and safety infrastructure, the underlying problems with low wages, working too many hours, inadequate enforcement of labor rights, and vulnerability of workers have not been solved. The research confirms that there have been no proportional gains in the well-being of workers in the RMG sector as the economic growth indicates.

One of the research findings that come out clearly is that the improvements that are being made are predominantly superficial and not a result of inner change but saturation. The factory environments have been visible to change through compliance efforts prompted by international buyers, and world standards. Nevertheless, there is not enough evidence that these changes have been made to combat the more profound structural issues especially those to do with fair pay, worker empowerment, and fair labor practices. The findings further indicate that workers have limited practical ability to exercise labor rights due to weak grievance systems, restricted worker participation, and limited freedom of association within factory environments. This has made a lot of workers still languish in economic poverty and low employment security even though they work in a sector that is globally important.

Another significant aspect of the research is the necessity to be acquainted with labor conditions in the context of the global supply chain. The persistence of exploitative practices is facilitated by international buyer pressure, competition in terms of costs and a weak governance structure. Factories run with tight margins and deadlines to meet and therefore encourage cost cutting strategies that usually compromise the rights and well-being of the workers. This system of interdependence shows that there should not be the blame of factory owners only on the labor conditions but spreads among several stakeholders, such as multinational brands, policymakers, and regulators.

Additionally, the gender aspect has highlighted the fact that women workers are still being discriminated against structurally in spite of the fact that they occupy the core of the industry. Their experiences are empowering yet vulnerable one, and gender sensitive policies are crucial. The involvement of the female population in the labor market has also led to economic growth and social transformation, although issues like gender based discrimination in the workplace, lack of childcare facilities, and careers have remained a challenge to most.

Besides this, the research highlights that the need to ensure sustainable development in the RMG sector should incorporate social, economical and environmental factors. The enhancements in the labor conditions must be accompanied by environmental responsibility and inclusive growth policies.

Altogether, the research finds that the only way to make the RMG sector sustainable and ethical is to systematically change the industry and not just follow the compliance rules but also focus on economic and social frameworks. To achieve long-term advances, the concerted efforts of the governmental bodies, industry stakeholders, and foreign players will be necessary to establish an industrial order that will be more equitable and person-centered.

6.2 Policy Recommendations

6.2.1 Wage Reform

The introduction of Minimum wage standards should be replaced with Living wage standards to make sure that the workers have access to the basic needs, and have a decent standard of living. Living wage should be determined by the real price of housing, meals, medical treatment and education instead of be fixed at the lowest possible prices. Moreover, the timely and transparent payment of wages can create trust between employees and management and decrease the financial insecurity. Red tape and responsibility in distributing wages is essential. Ensuring that the use of overtime as a source of a basic income reduces is also critical as this will enable the employees to create a better work-life balance and minimize the level of physical and mental stress.

6.2.2 Regulation of Working Hours

Legal strict actions on working hour restrictions should be implemented to safeguard the workers against overworking and its adverse health and well-being effects. The government authorities

ought to tighten the inspection system and enforce actions to those factories contravening labor laws. Overtime practices should also be monitored in order to maintain the voluntary nature of overtime, fair pay, and to legalize overtime. Exploitation may be prevented through the use of transparent record-keeping. In addition, by offering incentives to factories that uphold ethics in the workplace (tax benefits, certifications, or special access to the international markets), it can be used as a way to enforce the rules and company-specific culture of responsibility and sustainable production in the industry.

6.2.3 Strengthening Workplace Safety

Practical emergency drills are especially needed to be conducted on a regular basis to make sure that workers are prepared to cope with any crisis and to act accordingly in the situation like during the fire, or evacuation of premises. The exercises ought to be periodically performed and under conditions that mimic real-life in order to develop confidence and awareness. Employee involvement in safety training is also paramount, as the employees will be able to know the risks and work towards achieving a safer working environment. Training programs that are inclusive can improve communication and coordination in the case of emergencies. Also, a better layout of the factories that enables less congestion would go a long way in improving safety levels because there would be effective evacuation routes, less panicking, and faster and safer movement of people whenever necessary.

6.2.4 Healthcare and Welfare

It is important to extend healthcare facilities at work places to produce a system that provides the workers with proper and timely medical care when either they have simple or serious health conditions. Medical personnel must be trained, equipped and provided with access to necessary medicines in a factory. Work-related illnesses can be identified, prevented and managed by carrying out occupational health programmes as part of routine health check-ups and creation of awareness programs. Moreover, it is becoming essential to ensure access to mental health support because workers tend to experience stress, fatigue, and anxiety because of the problematic working conditions, and adequate support mechanisms could enhance overall well-being and productivity.

6.2.5 Labor Rights Awareness

There is need to expand healthcare facilities in working places to come up with a system that will offer the workers suitable and prompt medical attention when they have minor or severe medical conditions. The factory should provide medical personnel with access to needed medicines, equip and train them. Occupational health programs can help identify work related illnesses, prevent and treat them through conducting of occupational health programmes as part of normal health checks, and development of awareness programs. In addition, access to mental health support is becoming a necessity as workers are more likely to be subject to stress, fatigue, and anxiety due to the problematic working conditions, and proper support systems might lead to the improvement of well-being and productivity.

6.2.6 Gender-Sensitive Policies

Maternity benefits should be enforced so that women workers have their benefits during their pregnancy and even after they have given birth to their kids so that their jobs are not lost and so that they have paid leaves and safe work environment. Development of childcare centers in or close to work places can highly reduce the weight carried by working mothers and help them to balance the work and family life. Better welfare of children and less absenteeism is also achieved through these facilities. Moreover, it is important to enforce the zero-toleration policy to harassment in the workplace to make the working environment safe and respectful. Abuse can be prevented by introducing clear reporting systems and rigorous disciplinary measures as well as raising sensitization to honor the dignity of workers.

6.2.7 Global Supply Chain Responsibility

It is important to put in place accountability measures on the international consumers so that the global brands bear the burden of the labour standards in their supply chains. Customers ought to be responsible in insane prices and restricted time deadlines, which lead to the exploitation of workers. The use of fair pricing models can assist in making sure that the factories have a proper compensation that they can use to provide fair wages and invest in safe working conditions. Furthermore, it is necessary to enhance the partnership of governments, brands, and factories to establish a balanced and sustainable mechanism. The implementation of the ethical practices and the long-term improvement of the RMG sector may be encouraged by joint initiatives, open policies, and common responsibility.

6.3 Future Research Directions

The present study can be improved on in future research by carrying out comparative analysis within various industrial regions. Comparison of differences in working conditions, implementation of labor rights between geographical areas like Gazipur, Dhaka, and Chittagong and management practices can answer more on how the local areas can determine the outcomes of labor. Comparative studies of this sort would be useful in pointing to best practices, region-specific issues to assist with more targeted and effective policy interventions.

It is also crucial to do longitudinal studies on reform of labor in order to comprehend how the reforms in terms of policies and regulations affect the workers. Alternatively to cross-sectional data, going forward, researchers may consider following a population of workers or factories over a period of several years, to determine the success of compliance programs, wage changes, and safety enhancements in the long run. Such a method would give a more dynamic perspective on progress and bring to the fore how reforms result into long-lasting advancements rather than short-lived reforms.

The other research area of interest in the future is the effect of green transition on workers. With the textile and garment industry adopting more environmentally conscious means, it becomes essential to look at the impact these modifications will have on employment, job security, and skill demands. A study can be made to determine whether green projects provide new employment opportunities to workers or whether they bring about new inequality especially among the low-skilled labor.

Lastly, one should pay more attention to the role of technology in managing labor. The introduction of automation, electronic supervision and data management tools is revolutionizing the world of production in the RMG industry. These technologies should explore the effect on productivity, autonomy of workers, surveillance and job security in the future. The high technology and the level of welfare of the workers will be a key understanding in terms of promoting the inclusiveness and equitable industrial growth.

6.4 Final Remark

The Ready-Made Garment industry is a key to the economy of Bangladesh, yet the sustained livelihood of the industry will ultimately rest on enhancing the life of the workers that make it work. The industry has been transformational in creating job opportunities, alleviating poverty, and enhancing industrialization, especially creating jobs to millions of women. Nevertheless, even these accomplishments can be termed as not entirely effective when the labor force remains affected by the problems related to low salaries, excessive working hours, poor working conditions, and inadequate access to fundamental rights.

To retain productivity, minimize labor turnover, and improve the image of the industry worldwide, it is essential to improve worker welfare. When the workers are fairly paid, healthy and safe, chances are that they will be motivated, efficient and even committed to their jobs. . On the other hand, not adhering to labor rights may cause industrial turmoil, reputational risk and competitiveness loss in the global economy, particularly due to the growing pressures to comply with ethical sourcing and responsibility in production among consumers and global stakeholders.

Additionally, the sustainability of the RMG sector should be considered in a holistic perspective that considers the equilibrium between the growth of the economy and social responsibility and justice alongside environmental consciousness. The policymakers, factory owners and global brands should collaborate together in order to make sure that the development is inclusive and equitable. This involves the adoption of fair wage regimes, enhanced legislation enforcement of labor laws, gender equality and spending on health and safety.

Moreover, the workers can be empowered by involving them in decision-making processes, educating them and conducting awareness campaigns to establish a more balanced and robust industrial system. Employees are in a better position to help with problem-solving and innovations in place of work when their voices are heard.

Finally, the future of the RMG sector in Bangladesh lies on how the sector will shift its low-cost production model into a rights-based and sustainable development model. Putting the well-being of workers on a high priority is not only an ethical requirement, but an effective strategic requirement in a long-term stability and competitiveness and growth that is inclusive.

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Appendix

Some pictures while my surveying:





